

## **An Introductory Word**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 1:1-2

Among the many books of the prophets, four books are mysterious: Isaiah, Ezekiel, Daniel, and Zechariah. We thank the Lord that, through the years, He has opened these books to us. In this introductory message to the life-study of Daniel, we will consider the subject, the contents, the central thought, and the sections of the book of Daniel.

### **I. The subject**

The subject of the book of Daniel is the destiny of Israel apportioned out by God, the contents of the seventy weeks (Dan. 9:24-27). The seventy weeks are the destiny apportioned out by God to Israel.

This book not only covers the destiny of Israel but also covers the Gentile government and Christ. The large human image in Daniel 2 signifies all of human government from Genesis 10 to Revelation 19. Our understanding of the history of the Jewish people and of the Gentile government would be inadequate without this book. The book of Daniel shows us that Israel and human government are for Christ. Christ is the centrality and the universality of God's move, and this move is intrinsically involved with Israel and the Gentile government.

The book of Daniel reveals five particular points concerning Christ. The first point is the death of Christ. Daniel 9:25 and 26 say, "From the issuing of the decree to restore and rebuild Jerusalem until the time of Messiah the Prince will be seven weeks and sixty-two weeks....And after the sixty-two weeks Messiah will be cut off." This word about Messiah being "cut off" is the clearest word in the Old Testament concerning the crucifixion of Christ. The crucifixion of Christ is the landmark of the ages. It is the landmark where the old creation was terminated for the germination of the new creation in Christ's resurrection.

Christ died an all-inclusive death. When He died, we and the entire old creation died with Him. Therefore, His death was an all-inclusive termination. The terminating death of Christ ushered in the resurrection, and in the resurrection the germination of God's new creation began.

The second point is the upcoming appearing of Christ (2:34-35, 45). He will appear as a stone cut out without hands to strike the great image (vv. 31-45) at its feet of iron and clay. The entire image, which represents all human government, will be crushed, not from the head to the toes but from the toes upward to the head. This smashing of the image from the toes to the head will occur at the coming of Christ, and it is something only God Himself can do. At Christ's coming, all human government, from Nimrod in Genesis 10 to Antichrist, the last Caesar of the Roman Empire, in Revelation 19, will be crushed and become like chaff blown away by the wind (Dan. 2:35). The coming of Christ will also be the opening of the eternal kingdom of God. Hence, Christ's coming will be the landmark which closes human government and brings in the eternal kingdom of God.

The third point is Christ as the Son of Man who comes to the throne of God to receive dominion and a kingdom (7:13-14). In Luke 19 Christ is portrayed as a certain man of noble birth who went to a distant country to receive for himself a kingdom and then to return (v. 12). Christ's coming to the throne of God to receive the kingdom from the God of the heavens takes place in Daniel 7. After Christ receives the kingdom, He will come back.

The fourth point is the excellency of Christ in Daniel 10. Before Daniel spoke in chapters ten through twelve about the destiny of Israel, he received a revelation of Christ in His excellency. Every part of Christ is excellent and precious (vv. 5-6). We need to see and know this excellent Christ before we can know the destiny of God's people.

The last point is Christ as the companion of the suffering witnesses of God. In chapter three, Nebuchadnezzar had Daniel's three companions, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah, thrown into the midst of a blazing furnace of fire because they would not bow down and worship the golden image which Nebuchadnezzar had set up (vv. 13-23). Three were thrown into the furnace, but to his astonishment, Nebuchadnezzar saw another person within the furnace. The fourth person was "like a son of the gods" (v. 25). This One is the excellent Christ, who goes through the same kind of blazing fire as His suffering overcomers. Whenever we are witnesses for God, testifying something for God, we may suffer. Yet, in our suffering, Christ as the Son of Man — the One who is qualified and capable of sympathizing with us in everything — comes to be our companion.

### **II. The contents**

The contents of the book of Daniel are the seventy weeks apportioned out by God for Israel (9:24-27). One week equals seven years. We use the word apportioned to indicate that God cuts the ages into portions.

#### **A. The first seven weeks of forty-nine years**

These seventy weeks are divided into three parts. The first part is seven weeks of forty-nine years, from the issuing of the decree to rebuild Jerusalem to the completion of the rebuilding.

#### **B. The sixty-two weeks of four hundred thirty-four years**

The second part is sixty-two weeks of four hundred thirty-four years, from the completion of the rebuilding of Jerusalem to the cutting off of Messiah (the crucifixion of Christ).

#### **C. The last week of seven years**

The third part will be the last week of seven years, the time of Antichrist's covenant with Israel, the last seven years of the present age of grace, divided into two halves. The first half will not be that crucial, but the last half, of three and a half years, will be very important, for that will be the time of the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21).

#### **D. The insertion of Israel's history between the first sixty-nine weeks and the last week**

There is an insertion of Israel's history between the first sixty-nine weeks and the last week, in the age of the church. This insertion may be called the age of mystery, the age of grace, or the age of the church. This age includes many mysterious things, such as the resurrection of Christ, regeneration, Christ living in us, and the life-giving Spirit. The history of Israel is physical, with nothing of a mysterious nature, but the church's history is altogether mysterious.

The first part of seven weeks and the second part of sixty-two weeks have already been fulfilled. A decree was given to rebuild Jerusalem (Dan. 9:25), and Jerusalem was rebuilt. The Messiah was cut off sixty-two weeks from the rebuilding of Jerusalem (v. 26). Hence, these two parts of the seventy weeks, which were prophecies, have become history.

### **III. The central thought**

The central thought of Daniel is that the ruling of the heavens (4:26) by the God of the heavens (2:37, 44) over all the human government on earth matches God's eternal economy for Christ to terminate the old creation for the germination of the new creation and to smash and crush the aggregate of human government and establish the eternal kingdom of God.

The God of the heavens rules over all human government. Human government began with Nimrod in Genesis 10. Prior to Genesis 10 there were no human nations; instead, there was only mankind as a whole without established nations. Nations began to be established by Nimrod, who built Babel, a prefigure of Babylon (Gen. 10:8-10). Human government will conclude with the coming Antichrist, who will be the last Caesar of the Roman Empire. All human government from Nimrod to Antichrist has been and will continue to be under the ruling of the heavens by the God of the heavens.

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In God's economy, Christ has terminated the old creation for the germination of the new creation in His resurrection through His death. This was achieved in His first coming. In God's economy, Christ, by His upcoming appearing, will also smash and crush the aggregate of human government throughout the history of mankind and will establish the eternal kingdom of God. All of these matters have been and will be intrinsically involved with Israel, either positively or negatively.

The entire world situation is under the rule of the heavens by the God of the heavens, to match His economy for Christ. Today the world situation, especially in Europe and the countries around the Mediterranean Sea, has been balanced and brought into a condition which is ready for Christ's return. He is at the door and the time is near. As we see this situation, we must wake up and realize that the world is not for us. We are for Christ, and every day we must prepare ourselves to meet Him. Then we will receive a reward from Him.

The book of Daniel covers some very important matters. First, this book covers the history of Israel. Without this book, the Jewish people could not have an adequate understanding of their history. Daniel also covers human government from Nimrod to Antichrist. Because Israel and human government are for Christ, the book of Daniel also reveals certain aspects of Christ. Christ is the center and the circumference, the centrality and the universality, of God's move.

### **IV. The sections**

The last matter to be covered in this message is the sections of the book of Daniel.

#### **A. The issue of the degradation of God's elect**

In Daniel 1:1 and 2, an introductory word, we see the issue of the degradation of God's elect — the captivity to Babylon.

#### **B. The victory, in their captivity, of the young descendants of God's degraded elect over Satan's further devices**

Actually, the book of Daniel has just two sections. The first section, comprising chapters one through six, concerns the victory, in their captivity, of the young descendants (including Daniel) of God's degraded elect over Satan's further devices. This victory was over the demonic diet (1:3-21); over the devilish blinding that prevents people from seeing the great human image (the totality of human government throughout human history) in Nebuchadnezzar's dream (ch. 2); over the seduction of idol worship (ch. 3); over the covering that hinders people from seeing the ruling of the heavens by the God of the heavens (ch. 4); over the ignorance concerning the result of the debauchery before God and the insult to His holiness (ch. 5); and over the subtlety that prohibited the faithfulness of the overcomers in the worship of God (ch. 6).

#### **C. The visions of the overcoming Daniel**

The second section of Daniel covers the visions of the overcoming Daniel (chs. 7—12). Daniel's faithfulness and victory gave him the position and the right angle to receive visions from God.

The first vision concerns the four beasts out of the Mediterranean Sea (ch. 7). These beasts refer to Babylon, Persia, Greece, and the Roman Empire, and they correspond to the head, the breast with the arms, the abdomen with the thighs, and the legs with the feet of the great human image in 2:31-33. The second vision concerns a ram and a male goat with its successors (ch. 8). The next vision concerns Israel in the seventy weeks apportioned out to them (ch. 9). The last vision (chs. 10—12) concerns the destiny of Israel. According to chapters ten and eleven, Israel's destiny is related to the king of the south (Egypt) and the king of the north (Syria). According to chapter twelve, Israel's destiny is also related to the archangel Michael's standing for Israel.

# **The Victory of the Young Descendants of God's Degraded Elect Over Satan's Further Devices (1)**

## **Over the Demonic Diet**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 1

The first six chapters of Daniel are concerned with the victory of the young descendants of God's degraded elect over Satan's further devices. In this message we will consider their victory over the demonic diet.

### **I. The issue of the degradation of God's elect — the captivity to Babylon**

The issue of the degradation of God's elect was the captivity to Babylon (1:1-2). Daniel 1:2 tells us that "the Lord gave" Jehoiakim king of Judah into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon "with some of the vessels of the house of God." The word gave here indicates that the king of Judah and the vessels were a present given to Nebuchadnezzar by God.

#### **A. Captured back to the place of the worship of idols**

For the children of Israel to be taken captive to Babylon means that they were captured back to the place of the worship of idols (Jer. 50:38).

#### **B. Back to the original place of the worship of idols by their forefather Abraham**

When God's people were captured back to the place of the worship of idols, they were taken back to Babel, to the original place of the worship of idols by their forefather Abraham (Josh. 24:2-3). The origin of Babylon was Babel in the land of Shinar — Chaldea — Babylon (Gen. 11:2, 9, 11:28; 10:10). Abraham was called by God out of Chaldea to Canaan to worship God (Gen. 11:31). By this, the worship of the unique God, which had been lost through Adam's fall, was resumed.

The people of Israel did not exist during the period of human history from Adam to Abraham. The history of Israel began with Abraham, the first Hebrew. Under the leadership of Moses, Abraham's descendants made their exodus from Egypt, and forty years later they entered the land of Canaan. Eventually, God's people were taken back to the original place of the worship of idols, the very place out of which their forefather Abraham had been called.

#### **C. The utter destruction of the testimony of God's elect in the worship of the unique God**

The captivity to Babylon was the utter destruction of the testimony of God's elect in the worship of the unique God, Jehovah, by the carrying of some of the vessels of the temple of God into the land of Shinar and their being put into the temple of idols (2 Chron. 36:6-7).

### **II. The victory of the young descendants of God's degraded elect over Satan's further device in the demonic diet**

"The king told Ashpenaz, the chief of his eunuchs, to bring some of the sons of Israel, including some from the royal seed and from the nobility, children in whom was no defect, who were good in appearance, who showed insight in all wisdom, understanding in knowledge, and apprehension in thought, and in whom was the ability to stand in the king's palace" (Dan. 1:3-4). Among such sons of Israel were some young overcomers whom God used to gain the victory over Satan's devices. Satan might have thought that God had been defeated and that on earth there no longer was the worship of God. The elect of God had been defeated, and God's purpose on earth had suffered loss. However, God was not disappointed, for He still had some overcomers — Daniel and his companions. In His sovereignty He had arranged for these young people to be taken to Babylon, where they were His overcomers. If God had not had these overcomers in Babylon, He would have been totally defeated. But because of their presence in Babylon, He was not defeated and could boast to Satan that even in Babylon He had His overcomers.

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#### **A. Nebuchadnezzar's devilish temptation**

Daniel 1:3-7 describes Nebuchadnezzar's devilish temptation.

##### **1. Seducing Daniel and his companions to be defiled in partaking of his unclean food, food offered to his idols**

The first temptation that came to mankind concerned eating (Gen. 3:1-5). In principle, all the temptations that come to us are related to eating. Nebuchadnezzar's devilish temptation was first to seduce Daniel and his three companions, the four brilliant young descendants of God's defeated elect, to be defiled in partaking of his unclean food, food offered to idols. Nebuchadnezzar provided Daniel and his three companions with the choice food to eat. To Daniel, that choice food was actually the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. That tree is something attached to Satan and even one with Satan, but the tree of life is something attached to God and one with God. To eat of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil is to become attached to Satan; to eat of the tree of life is to become attached to God. When Daniel and his companions refused to eat Nebuchadnezzar's unclean food and chose instead to eat vegetables, they were actually rejecting the tree of the knowledge of good and evil and taking the tree of life. Thus, even in Nebuchadnezzar's palace there were the two trees.

The choice food was defiling, not clean, for it had been offered to Nebuchadnezzar's gods. For Daniel and his companions to eat that food would have been to take in the defilement, to take in the idols, and thus to become one with Satan. If they had done this, God would have been finished and would have had nothing on earth for Himself and His interest. Then Satan could have boasted and said, "God, You have been completely defeated. You have nothing on earth to represent You and to be one with You." God had been defeated in His elect. Now if their descendants in the captivity, the younger generation, had followed in the steps of their fathers, God would have been fully defeated. But Daniel and his companions were for God. They were attached to God, they cleaved to God, and they were one with God because they took God in.

To eat Nebuchadnezzar's choice food is to take Satan as our supply and to become one with Satan. I am concerned that you may be eating the choice food provided for you by today's Nebuchadnezzar. If we are careless in our eating, in our shopping, in where we go, and in what we do, we may take in something related to idols, something demonic. We are what we eat. If we eat godly food — that is, if we eat God-food, God as our food — we will be one with God.

## **2. Changing their names**

In his devilish temptation of Daniel and his companions, Nebuchadnezzar also changed their names, which indicated that they belonged to God, to names that made them one with the idols. The name of Daniel, which means "God is the Judge," or "God is my Judge," was changed to Belteshazzar — "the prince of Bel," or "the favorite of Bel" (Isa. 46:1). The name of Hananiah, which means "Jehovah is kind," or "the favorite of Jehovah," was changed to Shadrach — "enlightened by the sun god." The name of Mishael means "Who can be like God?" but his name was changed to Meshach — "Who can be like the goddess Shach?" The name of Azariah, which means "Jehovah is my help," was changed to Abednego — "the faithful servant of the fire god Nego."

## **B. Daniel fighting the battle by countering the devil's temptation with bold rejection**

Daniel fought the battle by countering the devil's temptation with bold rejection (Dan. 1:8-13). Daniel did not play politics but was frank and bold.

## **C. God honoring Daniel's fighting**

God honored Daniel's fighting, and Daniel and his companions became the overcomers among the remnant of God's defeated elect. The elect were defeated, but the young overcomers were victorious. Their victory was God's victory. Because of this victory God could boast and tell Satan that in the midst of Babylon, Satan's territory, God still had some overcomers, four young ones who were victorious over Satan's devices.

## **D. God apparently being defeated but actually preserving His worship and testimony**

Because of the captivity in Babylon, apparently God was defeated in His interests on earth. Actually He preserved His worship and testimony through the young overcomers among His defeated elect. In Catholicism and Protestantism today God has some overcomers.

## **E. God blessing Daniel and his companions with knowledge and insight**

God blessed Daniel and his three companions with knowledge and insight in all learning and wisdom, and He blessed Daniel especially with understanding in all visions and dreams (vv. 17-20). This blessing was God's way of indicating that He agreed with these four overcomers.

## **F. God blessing Daniel with longevity**

God blessed Daniel with longevity, so that he lived through the captivity of seventy years and saw the release and return of the captives from the first year of Cyrus, the king of Persia, after the fall of Babylon (v. 21; 6:28; 5:30-31; Ezra 1:1-5). From God Daniel received wisdom, insight, understanding, and longevity. With him and his companions we see the story of God's victory continuing on earth through the young overcomers. I hope that today as well there will be groups of overcomers who will be God's boast to Satan.

## **The Victory of the Young Descendants of God's Degraded Elect Over Satan's Further Devices**

(2)

### **Over the Devilish Blinding that Prevents People from Seeing God's Vision Concerning Human Government Throughout History**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 2

In this message we will consider the victory of the young descendants of God's degraded elect over the devilish blinding that prevents people from seeing God's vision concerning human government throughout human history.

#### **I. Nebuchadnezzar's marvelous dream**

Nebuchadnezzar had a marvelous dream of a great human image (2:1). That dream should have impressed him deeply, but he forgot the dream because he did not have a heart for God's interest. Then his spirit was troubled to know the dream, and all the magicians, all the wise men of Babylon, and the Chaldeans were unable to tell him the dream (vv. 2-13). However, there was a man, Daniel, who set his heart on the spiritual things regarding God's interest on earth. He did not have the dream, yet he received the vision from God concerning it (vv. 17-23) and interpreted it (vv. 24-45).

#### **II. Daniel's vision from God concerning Nebuchadnezzar's dream**

In 2:14-45 we have Daniel's vision from God concerning Nebuchadnezzar's dream.

##### **A. God's vision given to Daniel**

Verses 17 through 23 speak of God's vision being given to Daniel.

##### **B. Daniel's interpretation of Nebuchadnezzar's dream**

Verses 24 through 45 are a record of Daniel's interpretation of Nebuchadnezzar's dream.

###### **1. Daniel's exalting of God**

In his interpreting of Nebuchadnezzar's dream, Daniel exalted God (vv. 25-30). He did not exalt himself.

###### **2. The contents of Nebuchadnezzar's dream**

The contents of Nebuchadnezzar's dream were a great human image and its destiny (vv. 31-45).

###### **a. Signifying the aggregate of human government throughout human history**

This great image signifies the aggregate of human government throughout human history (vv. 31-33), from the beginning of human government in Babel (Babylon) in the land of Shinar (Gen. 10:6-12), as signified by the head, to the termination of human government in human history in the Roman Empire with the ten kings, as signified by the ten toes. From its beginning to its termination, human government has done and will continue to do three things: rebel against God, exalt man, and worship idols (Gen. 11:4, 9).

###### **b. The head of gold**

In the great human image, the head of gold, corresponding to the first beast in Daniel 7:3 and 4, signifies Nebuchadnezzar, the founder and the king of Babylon (2:36-38).

###### **c. The breast and the arms of silver**

The breast and the arms of silver, corresponding to the second beast in 7:5, signify Medo-Persia (2:39a).

###### **d. The abdomen and thighs of bronze**

The abdomen and thighs of bronze, corresponding to the third beast in 7:6, signify Greece, including Macedonia (2:39b).

###### **e. The legs of iron and the feet partly of iron and partly of clay**

The legs of iron and the feet partly of iron and partly of clay, corresponding to the fourth beast in 7:7 and 8, signify the Roman Empire with its last ten kings (2:40-43).

In the Bible, according to the human image in Daniel 2, there are only four empires. In the sight of God, therefore, all of human government throughout human history is composed of four empires: the Babylonian Empire, the Medo-Persian Empire, the Macedonian-Grecian Empire, and the Roman Empire. According to the human point of view, the Grecian Empire ended with the death of Alexander the Great. However, according to God's viewpoint, this empire continued with Alexander's successors — his four generals who divided the empire into four sections — and it lasted until the beginning of the Roman Empire. Apparently the Roman Empire has also been terminated. Actually the Roman Empire continues to exist. According to the books of Daniel and Revelation, the Roman Empire will have as its last Caesar the Antichrist, with the ten kings signified by the ten toes of the great image. The Roman Empire, which began approximately thirty years before the birth of Christ, will last until the very end of the three and a half years of the great tribulation. The aggregate of human empires that began with Nimrod at Babel will consummate with the last Caesar of the Roman Empire with his ten kings. Thus, according to the Bible, we are still in the Roman Empire today.

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The culture of the world is an accumulation of culture from the time of Nimrod until the present. What began with Nimrod will conclude with Antichrist. The Babylonian, Medo-Persian, and Macedonian-Grecian Empires have vanished, but their culture remains. The Medo-Persian Empire adopted aspects of Babylonian culture, and the Macedonian-Grecian Empire adopted aspects of Medo-Persian culture. In the same principle, the Roman Empire adopted many elements of Greek culture and of the cultures that preceded it. Today we are still under the influence of Roman culture, especially in the matters of law, politics, and government. In this sense, the Roman Empire continues to exist, and we are still in this empire.

###### **f. The destiny of the great human image**

Daniel 2:34-35, 44-45 reveals the destiny of the great human image.

###### **1) To be crushed by a stone cut without hands, at its appearing**

The destiny of the great human image is to be crushed by a stone cut out without hands, at its appearing (vv. 34-35a, 44b-45; 7:13-14). This stone cut without hands is Christ.

As the stone that will crush the entire human government of mankind, Christ was not cut out with human hands (as indicated by "without hands" in 2:34, 45); He was cut by God through His crucifixion and resurrection. Through His crucifixion He was cut by being put to death (Acts 2:23), and in His resurrection He was cut out to be, first, the cornerstone for the building up of the church and the crushing stone to destroy the totality of human government (Acts 2:24; Matt. 21:42, 44b).

At His appearing as the stone cut out not by human hands, Christ will crush the great image from the toes to the head. This means that He will strike the ten kings with Antichrist. Revelation 19 speaks of the war between Christ and Antichrist. With Christ there will be His newly-married bride, composed of the overcomers, and with Antichrist there will be the ten kings with their armies. This war will be a fighting of the earth against the heavens, of man against God. Christ will defeat and destroy Antichrist and the ten kings.

According to Daniel 2, this will entail the crushing of the entire human image from the toes to the head. Verses 34 and 35a say, "A stone was cut out without hands, and it struck the image at its feet of iron and clay and crushed them. Then the iron, the clay, the bronze, the silver, and the gold were crushed all at once, and they became like chaff from the summer threshing floors; and the wind carried them away so that no trace of them was found." This signifies the complete destruction of all human government from Nimrod to Antichrist. Human government will therefore be terminated by Christ at His appearing as the God-cut stone.

The Bible reveals that Christ is a stone in three aspects. First, to the believers Christ is the foundation stone in whom they trust. Concerning this aspect of Christ as a stone, Isaiah 28:16 says, "Behold, I lay a stone in Zion as a foundation, / A tested stone, / A precious cornerstone as a foundation firmly established." Second, to the unbelieving Jews Christ is the stumbling stone (Isa. 8:14; Rom. 9:33). Regarding this aspect, Matthew 21:44a says, "He who falls on this stone shall be broken to pieces." Third, to the nations Christ will be the smiting stone. "On whomever it falls, it shall crush him to powder and scatter him like chaff" (Matt. 21:44b). Daniel 2 reveals Christ as the smiting stone crushing the great human image and causing it to become like chaff carried away by the wind.

When Christ comes as the smiting stone, He will not come alone. Rather, He will come with His bride. By that time Christ will have already gained the church, and He will have married His bride, as described in Revelation 19. After His wedding He will come both as the smiting stone and as the One who will tread the winepress (Rev. 19:15; 14:19-20; Isa. 63:2-3). Antichrist will gather a vast number of evil, rebellious human beings around Jerusalem, thus preparing the "grapes" to be trodden in the "winepress" by Christ. His coming will be a great surprise, for these rebellious ones will believe neither in Christ nor in God but only in themselves. Antichrist will even go so far as to say that he is God (2 Thes. 2:4; Dan. 11:36), and for his enjoyment will set up his tent between the good land and the Mediterranean Sea (v. 45). Then Christ as the God-cut stone will come with His bride to strike the toes of the image, destroying it from the toes to the head. In this way, human government will be crushed and terminated.

## **2) To be replaced with a great mountain which will fill the whole earth**

The great human image will be replaced with a great mountain, signifying the eternal kingdom of God, which will fill the whole earth (2:35b, 44a). This means that after Christ comes to crush the aggregate of human government, He will usher in the eternal kingdom of God on earth.

Daniel 2:35b says, "The stone that struck the image became a great mountain and filled the whole earth." This increase of the stone into a great mountain signifies the increase of Christ. The fact that Christ can increase is clearly revealed in John 3. Referring to Christ, verse 30 says, "He must increase." The increase in this verse is the bride spoken of in verse 29: "He who has the bride is the bridegroom." Christ, therefore, has an increase, and this increase is His bride. Just as Eve was the increase of Adam, the bride is the increase of Christ as the Bridegroom.

The church today is Christ's increase in life, but the eternal kingdom of God is Christ's increase in administration. In life Christ increases to become the church; in administration Christ increases to become the eternal kingdom of God. Hence, Christ is not only the church but also the kingdom of God. Both the church and the kingdom are His increase.

The parable of the seed in Mark 4:26-29 reveals how the kingdom of God is the increase of Christ. Verse 26 says, "So is the kingdom of God: as if a man cast seed on the earth." This seed is Christ as the embodiment of the divine life. According to the parable, this seed sprouts, grows, bears fruit, matures, and brings forth a harvest (vv. 27-28). From the time Christ came to sow Himself into the "soil" of humanity, He has been growing and increasing. Eventually, this increase will become the great mountain that fills the whole earth to be the eternal kingdom of God.

The word regarding Christ as the stone and the mountain in chapter two of Daniel reveals that Christ is the centrality and the universality of God's move. We may say that as the stone He is the centrality and that as the mountain He is the universality. The stone is Christ as the center, and the mountain is Christ as the circumference, the universality. Christ truly is the all-inclusive One. He is the stone and also the mountain; He is the church and also the kingdom. He with His increase is the great mountain that fills the whole earth.

## **III. Nebuchadnezzar's honoring of Daniel**

In 2:46-49 we see Nebuchadnezzar's honoring of Daniel. Nebuchadnezzar fell on his face and worshipped Daniel, commanding that they offer an oblation and incense to him and saying, "It is certain that your God is the God of gods and the Lord of kings and a Revealer of secrets, for you have been able to reveal this secret" (vv. 46-47). Then Nebuchadnezzar made Daniel ruler over the whole province of Babylon and chief of the prefects over all the wise men of Babylon. Furthermore, in response to Daniel's request regarding his three companions, Nebuchadnezzar appointed them over the administration of the province of Babylon. Thus, Daniel and his companions were appointed to govern in the province of Babylon.

## **The Vision of the Great Image—the Controlling Vision in the Book of Daniel**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 2

In this message I would like to give a further word concerning the vision of the great image in Daniel 2. As we will see, this vision is the controlling vision in the book of Daniel.

### **The entire image being Babylon**

In the interpretation of Nebuchadnezzar's dream in chapter two, only the head of the great human image was called Babylon. However, if the head is Babylon, the entire image must also be Babylon.

The Bible reveals that the human image seen by Nebuchadnezzar in Daniel 2 actually did not begin with Nebuchadnezzar but with Nimrod, who founded the city of Babel (Gen. 10:9-10). The building of Babel by Nimrod was the beginning of Babylon. Babylon has since continued through the Medo-Persian Empire, the Grecian Empire, and the Roman Empire. It will eventually include the last Caesar of the Roman Empire, Antichrist, with his ten kings, signified by the toes of the great image (Dan. 2:41-44). The book of Revelation tells us that under Antichrist, the last Caesar, the Roman Empire will be both political and religious Babylon. Revelation 18 refers to the empire of Antichrist as the political and physical Babylon, that is, "Babylon the Great" (v. 2). Furthermore, through Constantine the Great, who accepted Christianity as the state religion, the nature of Christianity was changed to become the Catholic Church, which in Revelation 17 is called "MYSTERY, BABYLON THE GREAT" (v. 5). This is the religious Babylon. Therefore, from the Bible we see that not only Babylon itself is Babylon, but even the Roman Empire is Babylon.

### **Babylon rebelling against God, exalting man, and worshipping idols**

According to our point of view, there are many different countries, nations, and empires. But in the eyes of God, the entire human government from Nimrod to Antichrist is Babylon. This human government — Babylon — has always done three things: rebel against God, exalt man, and worship idols (Gen. 11:4, 9). To worship idols is actually to worship the devil who is behind the idols. Wherever we may go, we will see that human government rebels against God, exalts man, and worships idols.

### **The stone cut out without hands appearing to crush the great human image**

When Babylon reaches its consummation, the stone cut out without hands will appear to crush the great image, beginning with the toes and the feet (Dan. 2:34-35, 44-45; 7:13-14). In His word to the Pharisees in Matthew 21, the Lord Jesus indicated to them that He is a stone. First, in verse 42 He asked them, "Have you never read in the Scriptures, 'The stone which the builders rejected, this has become the head of the corner. This was from the Lord, and it is marvelous in our eyes'?" Then in verse 44 He went on to say, "He who falls on this stone shall be broken to pieces; but on whomever it falls, it shall crush him to powder and scatter him like chaff." Here we see that Christ is the smiting stone. What will be smitten by Him and scattered as chaff? According to Daniel 2, it is the aggregate of human government, whose name is Babylon, which will be smashed and crushed into pieces by Christ as the stone cut out without hands.

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### **Today's world situation**

As far as human government is concerned, we need to consider what part of the great human image we are in today. As the result of studying the Bible and the world situation for over sixty years, I believe that today we are at the feet of the image, very close to the ten toes. The world situation, especially the situation in Europe, has been remodeled to fit in with the prophecies in the Bible. If we are clear about this, we will know where we are and what we should do.

The culture, spirit, and essence of the Roman Empire continue to exist, but the form and appearance of this empire have vanished. However, the form and appearance of the Roman Empire will be restored under Antichrist. The whole earth is now ready for the restoration of the Roman Empire and the appearing of the ten toes, which will bring in Christ as the stone to crush the aggregate of human government and usher in the eternal kingdom of God upon the earth.

### **The controlling vision in chapter two**

The vision in chapter two is the controlling vision of the entire book of Daniel. Chapter one is simply an introduction, whereas chapter two shows us a controlling vision, a vision that is the key to understanding Daniel's visions in chapters seven through twelve.

The four empires in Daniel 2 correspond to the four beasts in Daniel 7. In chapter two Nebuchadnezzar saw a great human image, but in chapter seven Daniel saw four beasts. The four main parts of the image in Nebuchadnezzar's vision correspond to the four beasts in Daniel's vision. The head of gold (2:37-38), signifying Nebuchadnezzar, corresponds to the first beast, which "was like a lion and had the wings of an eagle" (7:3-4). The breast and arms of silver (2:32, 39a), signifying Medo-Persia, correspond to the second beast, which resembled a bear (7:5). The abdomen and thighs of bronze (2:32, 39b), signifying Greece, correspond to the third beast, which was like a leopard (7:6). The legs of iron and the feet partly of iron and partly of clay (2:40-43), signifying the Roman Empire and its last ten kings, correspond to the fourth beast, which, being different from the other beasts, had large iron teeth and ten horns (7:7-8).

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Further details concerning these empires are found in chapters eight and eleven. In chapter eight we see that the second part of the great human image — Medo-Persia — signified by a ram (8:3-4) was defeated by the third part — Greece — signified by a goat with a conspicuous horn (vv. 5-8). Verse 8 says, "The male goat became very great. But once he became strong, the great horn was broken, and in its place four conspicuous ones came up toward the four winds of heaven." These four horns signify the successors of Alexander the Great. For details concerning these four horns, we need to read chapter eleven, which has much to say about the king of the south (Egypt) and the king of the north (Syria). In particular this chapter speaks about Antiochus Epiphanes, a notorious descendant of Alexander's successor in Syria.

### **Three types of Antichrist**

Antiochus Epiphanes was a type of Antichrist. The first type of Antichrist was Nimrod in Genesis; the second was Antiochus Epiphanes in Daniel; and the third was Titus, the prince of Rome who destroyed Jerusalem in A.D. 70. Thus, if we want a full picture of Antichrist, we need to study not only the book of Revelation but also these three types of Antichrist. With Nimrod, Antiochus Epiphanes, and Titus we have the picture, and in the book of Revelation we have the definition. When we put together the picture and the definition, we have a full view concerning Antichrist.

### **The controlling vision keeping God's people from the world**

I hope that we will all see the controlling vision in the second chapter of Daniel and that, in light of this vision, we will have a clear view regarding human government. In the eyes of human beings, there are different kinds of governments, some good and others bad. But in the eyes of God, every human government is a beast. Babylon, Persia, Greece, the Roman Empire — all are beasts. I can testify that this view has preserved me from the world for more than sixty years. We all need such a view, such a vision. If, as God's people, we see this controlling vision, we will be kept from the world and prepared for Christ's coming as the smiting stone which will crush the aggregate of human government and become a great mountain — the eternal kingdom of God — filling the whole earth.



# **The Victory of the Young Descendants of God's Degraded Elect Over Satan's Further Devices**

(3)

## **Over the Seduction of Idol Worship**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 3

In this message we will consider the victory of the young descendants of God's degraded elect over the seduction of idol worship.

### **I. Satan's strategy to seduce the young overcomers among God's defeated elect in the worship of idols through Nebuchadnezzar's blindness**

In chapter three Satan's strategy was to seduce the young overcomers among God's defeated elect in the worship of idols through Nebuchadnezzar's blindness (vv. 1-7). Nebuchadnezzar made a great image of gold, sixty cubits (ninety feet) in height, and set it up in the plain of Dura in the province of Babylon (v. 1). He might have been influenced to make such an image by the interpretation of his dream in chapter two. Nebuchadnezzar sent word to assemble the high officials and all kinds of officers and all the rulers of the provinces to come to the dedication of the image he had set up and commanded all the peoples, nations, and languages to worship his golden image (vv. 2-5). Whoever did not fall down and worship was to be thrown into the midst of a blazing furnace of fire (v. 6). Daniel's three companions were among the high officials gathered, but Daniel, the chief of the prefects over all the wise men in the province of Babylon, was not present. This seems unusual. I believe that Daniel stayed in a hidden place and prayed concerning the situation.

### **II. Daniel's three companions standing against the devilish worship and being accused by the Chaldeans**

Daniel's three companions, the young overcomers among the Jewish captives, stood against the devilish worship and were accused by the Chaldeans (vv. 8-12). The Chaldeans were jealous of Daniel and his companions and took their refusal to worship the golden image as grounds to accuse them before Nebuchadnezzar.

### **III. Nebuchadnezzar tempting the young overcomers by giving them another chance to worship the golden image**

Nebuchadnezzar, in rage and fury, tempted the young overcomers by giving them another chance to worship his golden image, with the threat of throwing them into a blazing furnace of fire (vv. 13-15).

### **IV. The answer of the three young overcomers**

The three overcomers answered, "If it be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the blazing furnace of fire, and He will deliver us out of your hand, O king" (v. 17). Their response to Nebuchadnezzar was impolite and very bold (vv. 16-18). Yet there was still something of the natural thought in their response. They said that God was able to deliver them from the blazing furnace. Actually, God did not need to deliver them from the furnace. He kept them in the furnace and made the fire of no effect (v. 25). They were bold, but they were not so spiritual. If they had been spiritual, they would have said, "Nebuchadnezzar, we are happy to go into the blazing furnace, because when we go He comes. He makes your burning furnace a very pleasant place."

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### **V. Nebuchadnezzar being filled with fury and commanding that the overcomers be bound and thrown into the blazing furnace of fire**

Nebuchadnezzar was filled with fury, and the countenance of his face was changed toward the young overcomers. He commanded that the furnace be made seven times hotter than usual, and that certain mighty men in his army bind the overcomers and throw them into the blazing furnace of fire (vv. 19-21).

### **VI. The young overcomers falling into the blazing furnace of fire bound up**

The mighty men were slain by the flame of the fire, and the three young overcomers fell into the blazing furnace of fire bound up (vv. 22-23).

### **VII. Nebuchadnezzar being astonished and speaking to his counselors**

Nebuchadnezzar was astonished and said to his counselors, "Did we not throw three men into the midst of the fire bound up?...Look, I see four men loose, walking in the midst of the fire; and they are not harmed. And the appearance of the fourth is like a son of the gods" (vv. 24-25). This fourth one was Christ. Christ had come to be with His three suffering, persecuted overcomers and to make the fire a pleasant place in which to walk about.

Our natural thought is that we need to leave the fire of our circumstances. We may think that if we have a troublesome husband or a bothersome wife, we should pray and ask God to deliver us out of such a situation. But the Lord would say, "I do not like to deliver you from this situation in your married life. Instead, I will keep you there, and I will come and make your environment a pleasant place."

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When the enemy throws us into the furnace, we should realize that we do not need to ask the Lord to deliver us. He will come to be with us and take care of us in our suffering, making our place of suffering a pleasant situation. I can testify of this from my experience of imprisonment under the Japanese invading army in China. During that time of suffering, the Lord was with me. One day, as I was talking to the Lord, I had the deep sense that He was there in prison with me. I wept before Him, saying, "Lord, You know why I am here." Instead of delivering me from prison immediately, the Lord, by His presence, made that prison a pleasant place. As the Lord was with those suffering overcomers in Babylon, so He will be with us in our suffering today.

### **VIII. The young overcomers coming out of the fire**

Nebuchadnezzar came near to the door of the blazing furnace of fire and said to the young overcomers, "Servants of the Most High God, come out and come here" (v. 26). Then the young overcomers came out of the fire, and all the high officials and the king's counselors saw concerning these young overcomers that the fire had no effect on their bodies and that the hair of their heads was not singed, nor had their clothes been affected, nor had the smell of fire come upon them (v. 27).

### **IX. Nebuchadnezzar blessing the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abed-nego**

Nebuchadnezzar responded and said, "Blessed be the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abed-nego, who has sent His angel and delivered His servants who trusted in Him and changed the king's word and yielded their bodies that they might not serve nor worship any god except their own God" (v. 28). The three young overcomers did not simply frustrate the king's word — they changed it. Instead of caring for Nebuchadnezzar's word, they changed it in nature and yielded their bodies that they might not serve nor worship any god other than their own God.

Nebuchadnezzar went on to make a decree that any people, nation, or language that spoke something offensive against the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abed-nego should be cut into pieces and their houses should be made a dunghill, because there is no other god who is able to deliver in this way (v. 29). Then the king caused the three young overcomers to prosper in the province of Babylon (v. 30).

The three young overcomers gained the victory over the seduction of idol worship. The whole universe saw their rejection of that devilish worship. Thus, God could boast to Satan that even in his territory, He had a people worshipping Him. They did not care for Satan. Today, in this dark age, everything seems to be discouraging. But there is still a group of overcomers to stand against the tide and to carry out God's worship, testimony, and interest on earth.

## **The Victory of the Young Descendants of God's Degraded Elect Over Satan's Further Devices**

(4)

### **Over the Covering that Hinders People from Seeing the Ruling of the Heavens by the God of the Heavens**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 4

Daniel is a book of the divine revelation concerning God's economy. In chapters one through six, this book does not present God's economy in theology or in teaching but in a series of cases. There are at least six cases recorded in Daniel 1—6 which show us what God's economy is and how God's economy can be carried out. These six cases are illustrations.

Apparently the cases in chapters one through six stand alone and have nothing to do with each other. Actually these cases are all connected. For example, to find the crucial point of the second case, the great human image in chapter two, we must go back to chapter one. The secret of understanding chapter two is in chapter one. Likewise, the secret of understanding chapter three is in chapter two, and so forth. The case in chapter six is a conclusion to the five foregoing cases.

In order to describe the first case, in chapter one, we must paint a portrait. First, we must portray the figure of a fighting, overcoming general, Nebuchadnezzar, who has just returned from Jerusalem to Babylon with many captives following behind him. Second, we see four brilliant young men among the captives. Third, these young men are specially chosen from among the captives and then presented with the king's choice food. Fourth, they set their hearts to keep themselves for God, and they reject the royal food and eat vegetables only. Nevertheless, the four become very pleasant, happy, and healthy. Then as a result, God's presence, wisdom, and insight are with them, and they can understand things ten times better than all the others in Nebuchadnezzar's realm.

The second case is in chapter two. That great, victorious general dreamed a dream that he could not understand. Because he was blinded by worldly glory and power, he could not understand the dream and eventually forgot it. However, there was a person named Daniel who did not care for worldly glory and power, who had a heart for God, and who had the ability and the capacity to understand this dream. He had not only the right position and the right angle to understand but also an intrinsic capacity in his being to understand. Thus, when such an unknown matter was brought to him, he had the insight. He saw through the worldly glory and majesty related to human government. Then he gave the king a vision to open his eyes. But Nebuchadnezzar was void of the capacity to know God inwardly. Although outwardly he was helped by Daniel to see that God is the Most High God, nothing within him was touched. Regarding Daniel as a hero, this great, overcoming general worshipped him and offered him an oblation with incense. This is the scene at the end of chapter two.

In his interpretation of Nebuchadnezzar's dream, Daniel said, "You, O king, are king of kings, to whom the God of the heavens has given kingship, power, and strength and glory....You are the head of gold" (2:37-38). As Nebuchadnezzar thought about Daniel's interpretation, he might have considered himself to be someone great. Thus, in chapter three he erected a large golden image, possibly signifying himself, for people to worship. It not only had a head of gold, but the entire image was of gold.

Daniel was a prefect ruling over the largest province of Babylon. He realized that the great image was being set up for people to worship, and he anticipated its dedication. Since he is not mentioned in chapter three, it is likely that he went away and prayed for God's victory. God had received much worship in the temple in Jerusalem, but that was destroyed, and the utensils for worshipping God were brought to Babylon. God's interests on this earth were lost. Nevertheless, there were some overcomers in Babylon, and Daniel was one of them. I believe that Daniel stayed away from the dedication of the image in order to pray for his three companions. In his prayer he might have said, "God, You must preserve us and keep Your worship on earth. Your worship should not be cut off, frustrated, violated, or changed by anyone."

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Daniel's three companions answered Nebuchadnezzar boldly, saying, "There is no need for us to give you an answer in this matter. If it be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the blazing furnace of fire, and He will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if He does not, let it be known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods nor worship the golden image that you have set up" (3:16-18). They were thrown into the furnace of fire, but the fire had no effect on them. Therefore, at the end of chapter three, the king admitted in a good spirit that these three young men had changed his word and were not afraid to yield their bodies to be killed. "Nebuchadnezzar responded and said, Blessed be the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abed-nego, who has sent His angel and delivered His servants who trusted in Him and changed the king's word and yielded their bodies that they might not serve nor worship any god except their own God" (v. 28).

At the beginning of chapter four, Nebuchadnezzar again offered praise concerning God. As we will see, in this chapter Nebuchadnezzar, who continued to walk in pride, was abased by God. God exposed him and showed him that he was not a gentleman but a beast.

#### **I. Nebuchadnezzar's praise concerning God**

In 4:1-3 we have Nebuchadnezzar's praise concerning God in His greatness, might, eternal kingdom, and everlasting dominion. In verses 2 and 3 he said, "It pleases me to declare the signs and wonders that the Most High God has done for me. How great are His signs, / And how mighty are His wonders! / His kingdom is an eternal kingdom, / And His dominion is from generation to generation."

#### **II. Nebuchadnezzar's testimony**

Verses 4 through 18 are a record of Nebuchadnezzar's testimony.

##### **A. Seeing a dream, and the magicians and Chaldeans not being able to interpret it**

Verse 5 says, "I saw a dream and it frightened me, and the imaginings upon my bed and the visions of my head alarmed me." He decreed that the wise men of Babylon make the interpretation known to him. However, the magicians, conjurers, Chaldeans, and diviners could not interpret the dream to Nebuchadnezzar (vv. 6-7).

#### **B. Daniel coming in to interpret the dream**

Eventually Daniel came in to interpret the dream. Nebuchadnezzar told him about the dream and then asked him to make the interpretation known to him (vv. 8-18).

### **III. Daniel's interpretation of Nebuchadnezzar's dream**

#### **A. Daniel being appalled and alarmed**

Having heard of the dream, Daniel was appalled for a while and his thoughts alarmed him. When Nebuchadnezzar told him not to be alarmed, Daniel said, "My lord, may the dream be for those who hate you, and its interpretation for your enemies!" (v. 19).

#### **B. The great tree signifying Nebuchadnezzar**

In his dream Nebuchadnezzar saw a great, strong, tall tree, beautiful in foliage, rich in fruit, and good for food. This tree signified Nebuchadnezzar himself (vv. 20-22).

#### **C. A watcher, a holy one, coming down from heaven and saying that the tree should be Cut down**

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In his dream Nebuchadnezzar saw "a watcher, indeed, a holy one, coming down from heaven and saying, Cut down the tree and destroy it; yet leave its stump of roots in the earth, but with an iron and bronze band around it, in the tender grass of the field; and let him be wet with the dew of heaven, and let his portion be with the beasts of the field until seven periods of time pass over him" (v. 23). In his interpretation Daniel explained that this signifies that the Most High God had decreed that Nebuchadnezzar would be driven out from among mankind, dwell with the beasts of the field, be made to eat grass as bulls, and lose his reasoning for a period of seven times, until he came to know that the Most High is the Ruler over the kingdom of men (vv. 24-25). Verse 26 goes on to say, "In that it was commanded that the stump of roots of the tree be left, your kingdom will be assured to you after you have come to know that the heavens do rule."

#### **IV. Daniel's counsel to Nebuchadnezzar**

After interpreting the dream, Daniel offered counsel to Nebuchadnezzar. He advised him, saying, "Break off your sins by doing righteousness and your iniquities by showing mercy to the poor, if there is a prolonging of your prosperity" (v. 27).

#### **V. The fulfillment of the dream coming upon Nebuchadnezzar**

Verses 28 through 33 show how the fulfillment of the dream came upon Nebuchadnezzar.

#### **A. Nebuchadnezzar's word as he walked upon the roof of the royal palace of Babylon**

After Daniel exhorted Nebuchadnezzar, God gave him twelve months to repent. However, there was no repentance and no change. One day while the king was walking upon the roof of the royal palace in Babylon, he looked at the great city and was filled with pride, saying, "Is this not Babylon the great, which I have built up as a royal house by the might of my power and for the glory of my majesty?" (v. 30).

#### **B. A voice from heaven telling Nebuchadnezzar that the kingdom had passed on from him**

While the word was still in the king's mouth, a voice came down from heaven, saying, "To you it is spoken, King Nebuchadnezzar: The kingdom has passed on from you" (v. 31). God would teach him to know that he was nothing and the mighty God, the Ruler over the kingdom of men, the One who gives the kingdom of men to whomever He wills, is everything.

According to his nature and his being, Nebuchadnezzar was not a man but a beast. For this reason, his heart was changed from that of a man's, and a beast's heart was given to him (v. 16). God also took away his human reasoning. In that very hour he began to eat grass as bulls, his body became wet with the dew, his hair grew like eagles' feathers, and his nails became like birds' claws (v. 33).

#### **VI. Nebuchadnezzar's return to normality and his testimony**

#### **A. At the end of these days Nebuchadnezzar lifting up his eyes to heaven, and his reason returning to him**

Nebuchadnezzar remained in this condition for "seven periods of time." I believe that this expression refers to seven weeks, to forty-nine days. At the end of these days, Nebuchadnezzar lifted up his eyes to heaven, and his reason returned to him (v. 34a). Because beasts walk on four legs, they look down, but humans walk on two feet and look up. Nebuchadnezzar's reasoning came back as soon as he looked upward toward the heavens. Because he had changed, his reasoning returned.

#### **B. Nebuchadnezzar blessing the most high and praising and honoring the ever-living One**

Nebuchadnezzar blessed the Most High and praised and honored the ever-living One, saying, "His dominion is an eternal dominion, / And His kingdom is from generation to generation; / And all the inhabitants of earth are considered as nothing, / But He does according to His will in the army of heaven / And among the inhabitants of the earth; / And there is no one who can resist His hand / Or say to Him, What are You doing?" (vv. 34b-35). Further, in verse 37 Nebuchadnezzar praised, exalted, and honored the King of the heavens, because His works are truth and His ways justice and because He is able to abase those who walk in pride.

As indicated by his praise at the end of chapter four, Nebuchadnezzar surely had learned the lesson to be abased and know God. In chapter three he set up a golden image because he was very proud. Chapter four follows to teach him a great lesson. Although he acted like a gentleman, he was a beast. After this chapter the record of Nebuchadnezzar comes to an end.

# **The Victory of the Young Descendants of God's Degraded Elect Over Satan's Further Devices**

(5)

## **Over the Ignorance Concerning the Result of the Debauchery Before God and the Insult to His Holiness**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 5

Daniel 5 is a continuation of Daniel 4. Chapter five covers the victory of the young descendants of God's degraded elect over the ignorance concerning the result of the debauchery before God and the insult to His holiness. What Daniel records in this chapter is based on the spiritual view for spiritual lessons. Chapter five follows chapter four to give us a clear view of certain spiritual lessons.

### **I. Belshazzar's debauchery before God and his insult to His holiness**

Daniel 5:1-4 describes Belshazzar's debauchery before God and his insult to His holiness.

#### **A. Making a great feast for a thousand of his lords**

Belshazzar (a descendant of Nebuchadnezzar and a king of Babylon) made a great feast for a thousand of his lords, and he drank wine before them (5:1). Here we see Belshazzar's debauchery before God. Debauchery is an overindulgence in eating and drinking for an adulterous purpose.

#### **B. Commanding men to bring the gold and silver vessels that Nebuchadnezzar his forefather had taken out of the temple in Jerusalem**

Belshazzar, under the influence of the wine, commanded men to bring the gold and silver vessels that Nebuchadnezzar his forefather had taken out of the temple in Jerusalem, that he, his lords, his wives, and his concubines might drink from them and praise the gods of gold, silver, bronze, iron, wood, and stone (vv. 2-4). They took the vessels that were for God's worship in His holy temple at Jerusalem and used them in worshipping idols. That was an insult to God's holiness.

### **II. The writing by the hand sent from God**

Verses 5 through 9 speak of the writing of the hand sent from God.

#### **A. The fingers of a man's hand coming forth and writing upon the plaster of the wall**

At the very moment that they were drinking wine and praising their gods, the fingers of a man's hand came forth and wrote opposite the lampstand upon the plaster of the wall of the king's palace (v. 5a).

#### **B. King Belshazzar's countenance changing and his thoughts alarming him**

When Belshazzar saw that part of the hand that wrote, his countenance changed and his thoughts alarmed him (vv. 5b-6). The joints of his hips loosened and his knees began to knock together. He was a threatened man and had no peace to drink, no peace to continue his debauchery.

#### **C. The king crying loudly to bring the conjurers, the Chaldeans, and the diviners**

The king called loudly to bring the conjurers, the Chaldeans, and the diviners. He said to the wise men of Babylon, "Any man who reads this writing and declares its interpretation to me shall be clothed in purple and shall have a chain of gold around his neck and shall rule as the third ruler in the kingdom" (v. 7).

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#### **D. All the king's wise men not being able to read the writing nor make its interpretation known to the king**

All the king's wise men came, but they could not read the writing nor make its interpretation known to the king (v. 8). Then the king was greatly alarmed. His countenance changed further, and his lords were perplexed (v. 9).

### **III. Daniel's interpretation of the writing on the wall**

In verses 10 through 29 we have Daniel's interpretation of the writing on the wall.

#### **A. Daniel being recommended, called, and brought before the king**

Daniel was recommended, called, and brought before the king (vv. 10-16). The queen mother recommended Daniel, saying that an excellent spirit, knowledge, insight, the interpretation of dreams, the declaring of riddles, and the solving of problems were found in him. She went on to say, "Let Daniel now be called, and he will declare the interpretation" (v. 12b).

#### **B. Daniel's answer to the king**

The king told Daniel that if he could interpret the writing and make its interpretation known, he would be clothed in purple, would be given a chain of gold around his neck, and would rule as the third ruler in the kingdom. In his answer to the king, Daniel said, "Let your gifts remain with you, or give your rewards to another; nevertheless I will read the writing for the king and make the interpretation known to him" (v. 17).

Before reading the writing and interpreting it, Daniel reminded Belshazzar of the experience of Nebuchadnezzar recorded in chapter four. Daniel regarded what happened to Nebuchadnezzar as a lesson not only for Nebuchadnezzar but also for all his descendants. For this reason, Daniel referred Belshazzar to his forefather's lesson in a rebuking tone. Nebuchadnezzar had been severely disciplined by God and, after he had learned the lesson, offered praise to God. Belshazzar should have learned something from this lesson, but he did not care about it at all. Thus, Daniel said to him, "You his descendant, Belshazzar, have not humbled your heart, though you knew all this; but you have exalted yourself against the Lord of the heavens....The God in whose hand is your breath and to whom all your ways belong, you have not honored. Then that part of the hand was sent from before Him, and this writing was inscribed" (vv. 22-24). Belshazzar was not expecting such a rebuke.

### **C. The interpretation**

In verses 25 through 28 we see Daniel's interpretation of the writing. This is the writing that was inscribed: "MENE, MENE, TEKEL, UPHARSIN" (v. 25). This is Daniel's interpretation of the matter: MENE — God has numbered Belshazzar's kingdom and brought it to an end; TEKEL — he has been weighed in the scales and found to be lacking; and PERES — his kingdom has been divided and given to the Medes and the Persians (vv. 26-28).

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### **D. Belshazzar's response**

Verse 29 tells us of Belshazzar's response to Daniel's interpretation. Belshazzar commanded that Daniel be clothed in purple, that a chain of gold be put around his neck, and that the proclamation be made concerning him that he should rule as the third ruler in the kingdom.

## **IV. The destiny of Belshazzar**

Verses 30 and 31 speak of the destiny of Belshazzar.

### **A. Belshazzar being slain that very night**

Verse 30 says, "In that very night Belshazzar the Chaldean king was slain." There is no indication in the record that Belshazzar repented or had some kind of change. Probably there was no time for him to repent.

### **B. Darius the Mede receiving the kingdom of Babylon**

I believe that while Belshazzar and his lords were engaging in debauchery, the Median army was approaching the city. Soon after Daniel interpreted the writing, the Median army entered the city and the palace and killed Belshazzar. Thus, verse 31 concludes, "Darius the Mede received the kingdom at about the age of sixty-two." That ended the Babylonian Empire.

In the first five chapters of Daniel, there are a number of lessons for us to learn. For instance, the lesson in chapter one is that we should not care for the worldly choice and the worldly taste but set our heart on God and have a taste only for vegetables, that is, for simple food. We should receive only simple things. If we do this, we will be one with God and will become wise.

In chapter five concerning the case of Belshazzar, we see the importance of being serious with God and not disregarding any spiritual lesson. Belshazzar did not benefit from the lesson learned by his forefather Nebuchadnezzar in chapter four. The case of Nebuchadnezzar teaches us that we need to be careful and not consider what we have achieved. The palace built by Nebuchadnezzar was vast. When he took a walk on the roof of that palace, he became proud and said, "Is this not Babylon the great, which I have built up as a royal house by the might of my power and for the glory of my majesty?" (4:30). This should warn us that our achievement may make us proud, and this may usher in God's judgment. God's judgment upon Nebuchadnezzar reduced him to nothing. This was the reason he could say of the Lord, "All the inhabitants of earth are considered as nothing, / But He does according to His will in the army of heaven / And among the inhabitants of the earth; / And there is no one who can resist His hand / Or say to Him, What are You doing?" (4:35). In 4:37 concerning the Lord, Nebuchadnezzar went on to say, "He is able to abase those who walk in pride." Belshazzar should have learned the lesson from Nebuchadnezzar's experience; however, he did not learn the lesson and suffered as a result.

Belshazzar's situation should make a deep impression on us. We all need to see that if we have received some lesson from God, we must regard that very seriously. If we disregard any lesson, we will suffer.

Among all the events in chapter five, or going along with all these events, God's economy was being carried out. God knew how to manage the world situation. Do not think that Darius the Mede came to kill Belshazzar by accident. No, that was God carrying out His economy. If He had left the empire in the hand of the Babylonians, there could never have been a return of the captives to Israel. Therefore, the empire had to be changed from gold to silver. This was God's doing. This was God's tempering, His balance in His economy, to fulfill His plan.

# **The Victory of the Young Descendants of God's Degraded Elect Over Satan's Further Devices**

(6)

## **Over the Subtlety that Prohibited the Faithfulness of the Overcomers in the Worship of God**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 6

Daniel 6 is very crucial because it shows us how God carries out His economy with His elect for Christ's coming. God desires to carry out His economy, but man is needed to pray for His economy on earth. God carries out His economy on the earth through His faithful channels of prayer. Satan's strategy is to frustrate the prayer which is for God's move. Thus, the center of this chapter is man's prayer for the carrying out of God's economy.

God's move is like a train which must have rails for its move. Man's prayers are like the rails which pave the way for God's move to go on. There is no other way to bring God's economy into fullness and into fulfillment except by prayer. This is the inner secret of this chapter.

### **I. The exaltation of Daniel as one of the overcomers in the captivity of God's elect in Medo-Persia**

Daniel 5:31 says, "Darius the Mede received the kingdom at about the age of sixty-two." It pleased him to set up over the kingdom a hundred and twenty satraps (a Persian loan- word meaning "protectors of the kingdom"), who would be throughout the whole kingdom (6:1). Daniel was set by King Darius to be one of the three chief ministers over these one hundred and twenty satraps (v. 2). Daniel distinguished himself among the chief ministers and satraps, and the king considered setting him over the whole kingdom (v. 3). By this time, Daniel was no longer a young overcomer but had become an older overcomer; he may have been close to one hundred years of age.

### **II. The subtle attack of Satan on Daniel concerning the worship of God**

In verses 4 through 9 we see the subtle attack of Satan on Daniel concerning the worship of God.

#### **A. The chief ministers and satraps, with the high officers of the kingdom, taking counsel together**

Being jealous of Daniel, the chief ministers and satraps "sought to find a ground for accusation against Daniel from the perspective of the kingdom, but they could find no ground for accusation or fault, inasmuch as he was faithful, and no negligence or fault was found related to him" (v. 4). Therefore, the chief ministers and satraps, with the high officers of the kingdom, took counsel together that the king should establish a statute and make firm an edict that anyone who made a petition within the next thirty days to any god or man besides the king should be cast into the lions' den (vv. 5-7). They appealed to the king, saying, "Now, O king, establish the edict and sign the writing so that it is not changed, according to the law of the Medes and Persians, which cannot pass away" (v. 8). The intention of the chief ministers and satraps was to destroy Daniel, but Satan, who was behind them, wanted to stop or cut off the channel of prayer God was using for the carrying out of His economy.

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#### **B. King Darius signing the edict**

King Darius signed the writing, that is, the edict, to establish it (v. 9).

### **III. Daniel's faithfulness in the worship of God**

Verse 10 reveals Daniel's faithfulness in the worship of God. "Now when Daniel came to know that the writing had been signed, he went to his house (in his upper room he had windows open toward Jerusalem) and three times daily he knelt on his knees and prayed and gave thanks before his God, because he had always done so previously." He had read the prophecy of Jeremiah which prophesied that the children of Israel would serve the king of Babylon for seventy years (9:2b; Jer. 25:11). Standing upon this word, Daniel must have prayed many times for the fulfillment of this prophecy and for the return of the captives. He prayed, and he would not let anything stop or frustrate his prayer. He knew that his prayer was for the carrying out of God's economy concerning His elect. Therefore, his prayer was a serious matter.

Today, prayer is the lifeline in the Lord's recovery. The more Satan tries to frustrate our prayer, the more we should pray.

### **IV. The accusation of the opposers**

The chief ministers and the satraps assembled and found Daniel making petition and supplication before his God (Dan. 6:11). Then they came near and spoke to the king concerning his edict, saying, "Daniel, one of the captives from Judah, has not respected you, O king, or the edict that you have signed, but three times daily makes his petition" (v. 13). When the king heard this, he was very displeased with himself, and he set his heart on delivering Daniel. Until the sun set, he made efforts to deliver him (v. 14). However, the opposers prevailed upon the king (v. 15).

### **V. Daniel's suffering of the persecution**

Knowing that the edict could not be changed, the king commanded, and the opposers threw Daniel into the lions' den (v. 16a). The king responded and said to Daniel, "Your God, whom you serve continually, He will deliver you" (v. 16b). A stone was brought and set over the mouth of the den, and with signet rings it was sealed by the king and his lords that nothing might be changed regarding Daniel (v. 17). Then the king went to his palace and spent the night fasting. No entertainment was brought before him, and his sleep fled from him (v. 18).

#### **VI. God's deliverance of Daniel**

In verses 19 through 24 we see God's deliverance of Daniel. The king arose at the first light and went in haste to the lions' den. When he had come near the den, he shouted to Daniel with a sad voice, saying, "O Daniel, servant of the living God, has your God, whom you serve continually, been able to deliver you from the lions?" (v. 20). Daniel replied, "My God has sent His angel and has shut the lions' mouth, and they have not hurt me, inasmuch as before Him innocence was found in me; and also before you, O king, I have done no harm" (v. 22). Just as the Lord did not quench the fire for Daniel's three companions, He also did not slay the lions for Daniel's sake. Instead, He shut the lions' mouth, making their teeth of no effect. The king was very pleased concerning Daniel, and he commanded that Daniel be taken out of the den. Thus, Daniel was removed from the den, and he was found completely unhurt, because he had trusted in his God (v. 23).

After Daniel was taken out of the den, the king gave commandment concerning the opposers. Those who had accused Daniel were thrown into the lions' den with their children and wives. They had not reached the bottom of the den before the lions overpowered them and crushed all their bones (v. 24).

#### **VII. God's victory over Satan in the worship of God on earth**

Verses 25 through 28 reveal God's victory over Satan in the worship of God on earth, even in a Gentile kingdom, through the overcomers in the captivity of His defeated elect.

##### **A. Darius the king writing to all the peoples, nations, and languages concerning the God of Daniel**

Darius the king wrote to all the peoples, nations, and languages that dwell in the whole earth, making a decree that in all the dominion of his kingdom men tremble and fear before the God of Daniel. "For He is the living God / And enduring forever; / And His kingdom is one which will not be destroyed, / And His dominion will be unto the end. / He delivers and rescues, / And He does signs and wonders / In heaven and on earth; / It is He who has delivered Daniel from the power of the lions" (vv. 26-27).

##### **B. Daniel prospering in the reign of Darius and in the reign of Cyrus the Persian**

Chapter six concludes by saying that Daniel prospered in the reign of Darius and in the reign of Cyrus the Persian (v. 28).

Daniel's victory over the subtlety that prohibited the faithfulness of the overcomers in the worship of God was the last step of the victory over Satan's devices. Without these overcomers, God would have been fully defeated by Satan, having nothing on earth for Himself.

During the time of Nimrod and Babel, God's interest was also frustrated, but He had a way to gain Abraham to be His worshipper (Acts 7:2; Gen. 12:1-3, 8). After Abraham arrived in Canaan, he built an altar, and this was pleasing to God. God could boast to Satan and say, "Look, Satan, I still have at least one worshipper. The time is coming when the descendants of this worshipper will become a priestly nation to worship Me and serve Me." Eventually, as an issue of Abraham, the temple for the worship of God was built in Jerusalem.

When Satan sent Nebuchadnezzar to destroy the holy city with the temple in order to take away God's worship and service, it seemed that God was defeated and that His interest, worship, and service on earth were destroyed. Yet under God's sovereignty, four of the young men selected by Nebuchadnezzar to stand in the king's palace became overcomers to keep God's worship and service. God had four young overcomers living in the palace day by day, yet they were absolutely one with God. This was a shame to Satan and a boast to God. God could tell Satan, "Satan, do you think that My worship and service on earth are finished? Look at My overcomers. I have four overcomers worshipping Me and serving Me in the palace of Nebuchadnezzar." Today, as long as there are some overcomers on this earth, regardless of the number, God will have reason to boast. When God sees today's overcomers standing on the ground of the church, He will be happy and pleased.



## **The Visions of the Overcoming Daniel**

(1)

### **The Vision Concerning the Four Beasts Out of the Mediterranean Sea**

(1)

Scripture Reading: Dan. 7:1-8, 11-12, 15-28

The book of Daniel has two main sections. The first section (1:3—6:28), which comprises six cases, speaks of the victory, in their captivity, of the young descendants of God's degraded elect over Satan's further devices. The second section (chs. 7—12) records the visions of the overcoming Daniel. Daniel's faithfulness and victory gave him the position and the right angle to receive the visions from God.

Daniel received vision after vision. He received visions from God not only concerning the destiny of His elect but also concerning God's eternity. This book, at its highest point, touches the matter of how God intends to spend His eternity.

In chapters two and four, Nebuchadnezzar, a Gentile king, saw two great visions — a great human image and a big tree. Although Nebuchadnezzar saw these visions, Daniel was needed to interpret them. The big tree in chapter four corresponds to the head of the human image in chapter two: both signify Nebuchadnezzar. When the head was touched by God, the tree was cut down, and Nebuchadnezzar became a beast (4:16, 25).

In the first vision, the head of the great human image was gold. Each successive part of the image was made of different metals from silver to bronze and eventually to iron. In man's eyes these four metals represent four great human governments and cultures. However, what Daniel saw in the vision in chapter seven was very different. Instead of four different metals, he saw four cruel beasts. We need to study carefully the description of these four beasts.

#### **I. The year of this vision**

Daniel 7:1 says, "In the first year of Belshazzar king of Babylon Daniel saw a dream and visions of his head upon his bed. Then he wrote down the dream; he related the sum of the matters." This indicates that the year of the vision in chapter seven was the first year of Belshazzar king of Babylon, about 555 B.C. The captivity began in 606 B.C., and the return of the children of Israel from captivity took place in 536 B.C., nineteen years after Daniel saw this vision.

#### **II. The four beasts out of the Mediterranean Sea**

Daniel 7:2-8 describes the four beasts which came out of the Mediterranean Sea. The Mediterranean Sea was the center of the inhabited earth. God's economy in His creation was to make the Mediterranean area the center of culture up to the time of Columbus. Human culture has become a great sea full of winds and storms.

##### **A. The four winds of heaven stirring up the great sea and four great beasts coming up from the sea**

The four winds of heaven stirred up the great sea, and four beasts came up from the sea (vv. 2-3). This does not mean that heaven is the source of these beasts but that heaven arranged the situation that produced the four beasts. The four winds signify moves of heaven from four directions; the stirring up of the great sea signifies the stirring up of the political situation around the Mediterranean Sea; and the four beasts which came up from the sea signify four great, fierce, cruel, and inhuman kings with their empires (v. 17).

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##### **B. The contrast between Nebuchadnezzar's dream of the great human image and Daniel's vision of the four beasts out of the sea**

In chapter two, in Nebuchadnezzar's dream human government on the earth was signified by a great human image full of glory and splendor. In chapter seven it was unveiled to God's prophet, Daniel, that the heads of human government on the earth, and the governments themselves, were signified by wild beasts.

##### **C. The first beast**

###### **1. Corresponding to the head of gold of the great human image**

The first beast (v. 4) corresponds to the head of gold of the great human image in 2:36-38, signifying Babylon with its founder and king Nebuchadnezzar.

###### **2. Like a lion**

The first beast was like a lion — the king of the beasts, the most fierce and cruel.

###### **3. Having the wings of an eagle**

The first beast also had the wings of an eagle. The eagle is the king of the fowls. The beast's eagle wings signify that it was in the air, which belongs to Satan, the ruler of the air, and that its move was swift.

###### **4. Its wings being plucked**

Daniel tells us that he watched until the wings of this beast were plucked. This plucking of its wings signifies that its moving power was taken away and that it became like a beast in the field, as mentioned in 4:23-25a. When God touched Nebuchadnezzar, he became like a beast in the field.

###### **5. Lifted up from the earth and made to stand on two feet like a man**

"It was lifted up from the earth and made to stand on two feet like a man; and a man's heart was given to it" (7:4b). This means that it became like a man standing on the earth with a man's heart, as indicated in 4:25b, 32b.

##### **D. The second beast**

###### **1. Corresponding to the breast and arms of silver of the great human image**

The second beast (7:5) corresponds to the breast and arms of silver of the great human image in 2:32, 39a, signifying Medo-Persia.

###### **2. Resembling a bear**

The second beast resembled a bear. This signifies that it was not as strong and swift as the lion but that it was still fierce and cruel.

###### **3. Raising up on one side**

This beast raised up on one side. This signifies that Media and Persia became one dominion.

###### **4. Three ribs being in its mouth between its teeth**

Three ribs were in its mouth between its teeth. This signifies that three kingdoms, Babylon, Asia Minor, and Egypt, were devoured by it.

## **5. Being commanded to arise and devour much flesh**

The second beast was commanded to arise and devour much flesh. This signifies that it would devour more nations.

## **E. The third beast**

### **1. Corresponding to the abdomen and thighs of bronze of the great human image**

The third beast (7:6) corresponds to the abdomen and thighs of bronze of the great human image in 2:32, 39b, signifying Greece with its king, Alexander the Great.

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### **2. Like a leopard**

The third beast was like a leopard. This signifies that it was fierce, cruel, and swift (Hab. 1:8a).

### **3. Having four wings of a bird on its back**

This beast had four wings of a bird on its back. This signifies that it was swift by means of its four generals, like a bird with four wings.

### **4. Having four heads**

The beast had four heads. This signifies that the four wings for swiftness became four heads, four generals who became the heads of four kingdoms. After the death of Alexander the Great, his four generals divided his empire into four kingdoms.

### **5. Given dominion**

The third beast was given dominion. This signifies that it was given authority to rule over the nations.

## **F. The fourth beast**

The fourth beast (7:7-8) is the beast as revealed in Revelation 13:1-2.

### **1. Corresponding to the legs of iron and the feet partly of iron and partly of clay of the great human image**

The fourth beast corresponds to the legs of iron and the feet partly of iron and partly of clay of the great human image in 2:40-43, signifying the Roman Empire.

### **2. Being dreadful and frightful and exceedingly strong**

As signified by iron, the fourth beast was dreadful and frightful and exceedingly strong.

### **3. Having large iron teeth and claws of bronze and devouring, crushing, and trampling the remainder with its feet**

This beast had large iron teeth and claws of bronze, and it devoured, crushed, and trampled under the remainder (v. 19). This signifies that it had great power to devour and crush nations and trample down the remainder.

### **4. Having ten horns**

The beast had ten horns (7:20a). This signifies that it had ten kings (Rev. 17:12-13).

### **5. A small horn coming up among the ten horns, and three of them being uprooted before it**

A small horn came up among the ten horns, and three of them were uprooted before them (Dan. 7:8a, 20b, 24). This signifies that Antichrist will come up among the ten kings, and before him three of them will be destroyed. In this way Antichrist will become the strongest horn.

#### **a. In this horn there being eyes like the eyes of a man and a mouth speaking great things**

In this horn were eyes like the eyes of a man and a mouth speaking great things (Dan. 7:8b, 20c, 25a). This signifies that Antichrist will have sharp sight to perceive things and a mouth to speak great things against God (Rev. 13:5a, 6). Because of this, Antichrist will be slain, and his body will be destroyed and given to the burning fire (Dan. 7:11; Rev. 19:20).

#### **b. This horn waging war with the saints**

This horn (Antichrist) waged war with the saints, wore out the saints of the Most High for three and a half years, and prevailed against them (Dan. 7:21, 25; Rev. 13:7a).

#### **c. This horn intending to change the times and the law**

This horn (Antichrist) intended to change the times and the law (Dan. 7:25).

#### **d. This horn being judged by God and his dominion being taken away**

This horn (Antichrist) will be judged by God, and his dominion will be taken away, so that it will be annihilated and destroyed unto the end (vv. 11b, 26).

### **6. The kingdom and the dominion and the greatness of the kingdoms under the whole heaven being given to the people of the saints of the Most High**

According to 7:22 and 27, the kingdom and the dominion and the greatness of the kingdoms under the whole heaven will be given to the people of the saints of the Most High.

## **G. Concerning the rest of the beasts**

As for the rest of the beasts, their dominion (authority and kingdom) was taken away, but an extension of life (culture) was given to them for a season and for a time (v. 12). This indicates that although the dominion and authority of Babylon, Persia, and Greece were taken away, their life, that is, their culture, will be extended and still remain. Today we are a part of Western culture, the Roman culture. Western culture is the consummation of Roman, Greek, Persian, and Babylonian culture.

Belshazzar, the Babylonian king, was defeated by Darius the Mede. Then Alexander the Great came to defeat Darius the Persian (a different Darius) in 330 B.C. Alexander's four generals succeeded him to rule over four kingdoms. In 27 B.C. Caesar Augustus became the emperor of the Roman Empire, replacing the Grecian Empire. Although the actual Roman Empire came to an end around A.D. 476, the Roman spirit, culture, law, politics, and customs continue to exist. Therefore, in a sense, today we are still a part of the Roman Empire.

The books of Daniel and Revelation unveil God's economy. According to His economy, God will rule over the world, produce a situation for Israel to be His elect, gain the church to be His mysterious people, and have all the nations to be the peoples in the eternal kingdom of God. If we see this, we will know where we are, and we will know the meaning of our human life.

## **The Visions of the Overcoming Daniel**

(1)

### **The Vision Concerning the Four Beasts Out of the Mediterranean Sea**

(2)

Scripture Reading: Dan. 7:9-10, 13-14, 26-27

In this message we will consider further the vision in Daniel 7 concerning the four beasts out of the Mediterranean Sea. We have seen that these four beasts are dreadful and terrible, doing whatever they desire as if there were no God in the universe. However, this chapter reveals that the Ancient of Days is still on the throne.

#### **III. God and His universal dominion**

Daniel 7:9 and 10 speak of God and His universal dominion.

##### **A. Thrones being set and the Ancient of Days sitting down**

Verse 9a says, "I watched / Until thrones were set, / And the Ancient of Days sat down. / His clothing was like white snow, / And the hair of His head was like pure wool." This signifies that God is ancient.

##### **B. His throne being flames of fire**

His throne was flames of fire; its wheels were burning fire; and a stream of fire issued forth and came out from before Him (vv. 9b-10a). Everything around Him is fire, meaning that God is absolutely righteous and altogether holy. Without holiness no one can see the Lord or contact Him (Heb. 12:14).

##### **C. Thousands of thousands ministering to Him**

Thousands of thousands ministered to Him, and ten thousands of ten thousands stood before Him (Dan. 7:10b). This vast number of angels ministered to Him for His service and stood before Him for His glory.

##### **D. The court of judgment sitting**

The court of judgment sat, mainly to judge the four human empires signified by the four wild beasts (vv. 10c, 26). A special court, with God's throne as the center, has been set up in the universe to judge the four human empires. Everything that is judged by this court will be cast into the burning fire.

#### **IV. The coming of the Son of Man — Christ**

Concerning His judgment, God has given all power and authority to Jesus Christ as the Son of Man (John 5:22). Hence, Daniel 7:13 and 14 describe the coming of the Son of Man — Christ.

##### **A. Christ coming like a Son of Man with the clouds of heaven**

According to verse 13a, Christ came like a Son of Man with the clouds of heaven.

##### **B. Coming to the Ancient of Days and being brought near before Him**

The Son of Man, Christ, came to the Ancient of Days and was brought near before Him (v. 13b). The coming here is Christ's ascending.

Daniel 9:26, referring to the death of Christ on the cross for our redemption, speaks of Messiah's being cut off. This was a great achievement, the work of redemption, accomplished by Christ in His first appearance on earth. After Christ accomplished the work of redemption, He ascended to the heavens.

This could be mentioned in Daniel 7 because there is no time element with God. In the sight of God, immediately after accomplishing redemption, Christ ascended to the heavens, coming to God to receive the kingdom. This indicates that from God's point of view the kingdom comes right after redemption.

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Daniel did not have any idea concerning the church. Like Abraham, David, and the other prophets, he did not see the mystery of the church which has been hidden from the ages and from the generations. He did not realize that between the first and second appearing of Christ there would be a period of time during which God would do a marvelous and mysterious work based on Christ's redemption. This work is to regenerate His redeemed people and then sanctify them, renew them, transform them, and conform them to the glorious image of Christ. According to Daniel's vision, Christ accomplished redemption and then immediately came to God in ascension to receive the kingdom.

##### **C. To Him being given dominion, glory, and a kingdom, that all the peoples, nations, and languages might serve Him**

To Him was given dominion, glory, and a kingdom, that all the peoples, nations, and languages might serve Him. His dominion is an eternal dominion, which will not pass away, and His kingdom is one that will not be destroyed (v. 14; Luke 19:12, 15a). This is Christ's kingdom; it is also God's kingdom.

##### **D. Coming as a stone cut out without hands to strike the great human image**

In His second appearing Christ will come as a stone (Matt. 21:44b) cut out without hands (not by man's hands) to strike the great human image (the human government on earth) on its feet of iron and clay (the Roman Empire under Antichrist) and crush the iron, the clay, the bronze, the silver, and the gold (the entire human government on earth). All the materials of the great image will become like chaff from the summer threshing floors, and the wind will carry them away so that no trace of them will be found (Dan. 2:34-35a, 45a). The cumulative culture of all the empires signified by the gold, the silver, the bronze, the iron, and the clay will be crushed by this stone. Thus, the Lord will clear up the entire old creation.

## **E. Becoming a great mountain**

As the stone cut out without hands, Christ will become a great mountain (a great kingdom — the eternal kingdom of God) and will fill the whole earth forever and ever (2:35b, 44). In Mark 4 He was sown as a little seed to be the kingdom of God, but He grows in His increase to become a stone, the increased kingdom of God. Then He will increase further and further until He becomes the great mountain, the eternal kingdom of God. This is the Christ who fills all in all, and the church is His Body.

## **F. Christ's coming terminating the entire human government and bringing in the eternal kingdom of God**

Christ's coming will terminate the entire human government on earth from its end to its beginning, and it will bring in the eternal kingdom of God.

The crushing of the great human image from the toes to the head will be Christ's universal judgment upon the aggregate of the human government from Antichrist back to Nimrod. In this way Christ will clear up the old creation. In His first coming Christ terminated the old creation through His death on the cross. Then in His resurrection He germinated the new creation. All this is mysterious. Outwardly, the world remains the same, and the human government that began with Nimrod continues to exist. For this reason, there is the need of Christ's second coming, His second appearing, to clear up the old creation outwardly and physically by His smashing the great human image. That clearing up of the old creation in its human government will usher in the universal and eternal kingdom of God. In the kingdom the Lord will enjoy the fruit of His work — being one with His redeemed people.

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## **G. The book of Daniel bearing a particular characteristic**

The book of Daniel bears a particular characteristic, that is, to draw the marking lines of the ages.

### **1. The cutting off of Messiah**

First, the cutting off of Messiah (the crucifixion of Christ) in 9:26 terminated the age of the old creation for the germination of the age of the new creation in Christ's resurrection. In His crucifixion He, the last Adam, terminated the old creation, and in His resurrection He became the germinating Spirit, the life-giving Spirit (1 Cor. 15:45b) to germinate us in His resurrection.

Paul tells us that Christ's death terminated the old creation, for our old man was crucified with Him (Rom. 6:6). This termination of the old creation is for the germination of the new creation. In 2 Corinthians 5:17 Paul says, "If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation." In Galatians 6:15 he goes on to say, "Neither is circumcision anything nor uncircumcision, but a new creation." This new creation is the church. Through Christ's resurrection we have been germinated — that is, made alive, regenerated — to become the sons of God as the new creation to be the Body of Christ. When He becomes the King to rule over the entire earth, we will be a part of Him. He will be the King, and we will be His co-kings.

### **2. The upcoming appearing of Christ**

The upcoming appearing of Christ (Dan. 7:13-14) will end the age of man's government on earth of the old creation (which began from Babel in the land of Shinar — Gen. 10:8-12; 11:2-4 — and will be destroyed at the end of the present age), and it will initiate the age of God's dominion over the entire earth in the millennium and in the new heaven and new earth. The entire universe will be new.

Two things are problems to God — the old creation produced out of Adam and the human government. According to the vision in Daniel 7, every kind of human government is a beast. The first problem — the old creation — was solved through Christ's death. The second problem — human government — will be solved by Christ's coming as the stone cut out without hands to crush the great human image, thus ending the age of man's government on earth in the old creation.

### **3. The seventy weeks**

The seventy weeks unveiled in 9:24-27 show the lines of the age of the return of Israel from their captivity and the rebuilding of their holy temple and their holy city until the crucifixion of Christ; the age of mystery (the age of the church), the length of which is unknown; and the last seven years of the present age, which usher in the millennium and the new heaven and new earth for eternity.

We need to have a clear view concerning chapter seven of Daniel. This chapter covers a vast span — from Babylon, the first beast, to the new heaven and new earth. If we have such a clear view, we will know where we are today with respect to the parts of the great human image. I believe that we are close to the time of the ten toes.

## **V. The interpretation of the vision**

In 7:15-28 Daniel was given the interpretation of the vision which he had seen in verses 1 through 14.

## **The Visions of the Overcoming Daniel**

(2)

### **The Vision Concerning a Ram and a Male Goat with Its Successors**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 8; 9:27; 11:2-4, 30-35; 12:3; Rev. 13:5-7; 17:11; 19:20; 2 Thes. 2:3-4

In chapter seven Daniel saw a vision of the four beasts out of the Mediterranean Sea. That vision was a brief sketch without much detail. But chapters eight and eleven give many details concerning the second and third beasts, which correspond respectively to the Medo-Persian and Grecian Empires. In this message we will cover the vision of a ram and a male goat with its successors recorded in chapter eight of Daniel.

As we read Daniel 8, we may wonder what this chapter has to do with Israel. The Medo-Persian Empire, the Grecian Empire, and the Roman Empire were on the three continents of Asia, Africa, and Europe. At the intersection of these three continents is Israel. Throughout the ages Israel has suffered a great deal because of the fighting between these empires on these three continents, of which Israel is the center. Israel has often been the battleground. Due to the trouble and damage caused by this fighting, it has been difficult for Israel, God's elect, to be something truly according to God's eternal economy. This is the reason that God came in to show Daniel vision after vision concerning the world situation. Whereas chapters nine and twelve are concerned with Israel directly, chapter eight with its vision regarding Medo-Persia and Greece and chapter eleven with its vision regarding the successors of Alexander the Great are concerned with Israel indirectly.

#### **I. The year of this vision**

The year of this vision is given in 8:1. "In the third year of the reign of Belshazzar the king a vision appeared to me, Daniel, after the one that appeared to me at the beginning." This was about 552 B.C.

#### **II. The place of this vision**

Daniel 8:2 tells of the place of this vision. "I watched in the vision, and it happened that while I watched, I was in the fortress of Shushan, which is in the province of Elam; and I watched in the vision, and I was beside the river Ulai."

#### **III. The vision concerning a ram and a male goat with its successors**

The vision in 8:3-14 concerns a ram and a male goat with its successors.

##### **A. A ram**

Verses 3 and 4 speak of a ram.

##### **1. Signifying Medo-Persia**

The ram signifies Medo-Persia (vv. 3a, 20; 11:2).

##### **2. Standing before the river**

The ram was standing before the river (8:3b). This signifies that the ram became strong by the river Ulai.

##### **3. Two high horns, one higher than the other and the higher one coming up last**

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The ram had two horns, and "the two horns were high, but one was higher than the other; and the higher one came up last" (v. 3c). These two horns signify Media and Persia. Persia with its king Cyrus (Ezra 1:1), which came up last, became higher than Media.

##### **4. The ram pushing westward, northward, and southward**

Daniel saw the ram pushing westward, northward, and southward (Dan. 8:4a). This signifies that Medo-Persia conquered Babylon on the west, Assyria on the north, and Egypt on the south.

##### **5. No beast being able to stand before him, and no one being able to deliver from his power**

"No beast could stand before him, and there was no one who could deliver from his power" (v. 4b). This signifies Medo-Persia's subduing power.

##### **6. Doing as he pleased and becoming great**

"He did as he pleased, and he became great" (v. 4c). This indicates that Medo-Persia had no fear of God and became arrogant in itself. Eventually, God dealt with Medo-Persia by raising up Alexander the Great.

##### **B. A male goat**

Verses 5 through 8a speak of a male goat.

##### **1. Signifying Greece with Alexander the Great**

The male goat signifies Greece with Alexander the Great (vv. 5a, 21a; 11:3).

##### **2. From the west**

This male goat came from the west (8:5b). This signifies that it came from Europe, west of the Mediterranean Sea.

##### **3. Over the face of the whole earth without touching the ground**

The goat came over the face of the whole earth without touching the ground (v. 5c). This signifies its swift movement over the earth.

##### **4. Having a conspicuous horn between its eyes**

The goat had a conspicuous horn between its eyes (v. 5d; 11:3). This signifies Alexander the Great as an extraordinary horn distinguished by his two sharp eyes. He was very intelligent.

##### **5. The goat coming up to the ram, striking him, breaking his two horns, throwing him to the ground, and trampling him**

The goat came up to the ram in his mighty wrath, struck the ram, broke his two horns, threw him to the ground, and trampled him. The ram had no strength to withstand him, and there was none to deliver the ram from his power (8:6-7). This indicates that Alexander the Great conquered Medo-Persia and destroyed it.

**6. The male goat becoming very great**

The male goat became very great (v. 8a). This indicates that Alexander the Great became arrogant in himself.

**7. The great horn being broken**

Once the male goat became strong, the great horn was broken (v. 8a). This signifies that once Alexander the Great, the great horn of Greece, became strong in power, he died.

**C. The successors of the male goat**

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Verses 8b through 14 speak of the successors of the male goat.

**1. In the place of the great horn, four conspicuous ones coming up toward the four winds of heaven**

In the place of the great horn, four conspicuous ones came up toward the four winds of heaven (v. 8b; 11:4). This signifies that in the place of Alexander the Great, his four generals (corresponding to the four wings and the four heads in 7:6), Cassander, Lysimachus, Ptolemy, and Seleucus, rose up from the four ends of his empire to form nations in Macedonia, Asia Minor, Egypt, and Syria, respectively. According to the human point of view, the Grecian Empire ended with the death of Alexander the Great. But in the sight of God, the Grecian Empire continued to exist in the four empires formed by Alexander the Great's four generals. Eventually, these four empires were merged and formed into two empires, one on the south (Egypt) and the other on the north (Syria). Chapter eleven describes the warfare between these two empires in the territory of Israel.

**2. A little horn coming forth out of one of the four horns**

Out of one of the four horns came forth a little horn (8:9a). This little horn signifies Antiochus Epiphanes from Syria in 175-164 B.C.

**a. Growing very great toward the south, toward the east, and toward that which is beautiful**

The little horn grew very great toward the south, toward the east, and toward that which is beautiful (v. 9b). This signifies that he expanded very much toward Egypt on the south, toward Syria on the east, and toward Israel, which is beautiful. The expression "that which is beautiful" refers to the beautiful land of Israel.

**b. Growing great, causing some of the host and some of the stars to fall to the earth, and trampling them**

The little horn grew great, as high as the host of heaven, and he caused some of the host and some of the stars to fall to the earth, and he trampled them (v. 10; 11:30b-35). This signifies that he became great in power and persecuted the saints (signified by the host of heaven and the stars — 12:3). In all these evil things he typifies the coming Antichrist (Rev. 13:5-7; 2 Thes. 2:3b-4).

**c. Growing in greatness to that of the Prince of the host**

The little horn grew in greatness to that of the Prince of the host (God); and from Him the daily sacrifice was taken away, and the place of His sanctuary was thrown down (Dan. 8:11; 11:31). In all these evils also he typifies Antichrist (9:27).

**d. A host given to him for war against the daily sacrifice**

A host (an army of Israel) was given to him for war against the daily sacrifice because of transgression. He cast truth down to the ground, and he took action and prospered (8:12). He stopped the daily sacrifices in the temple and defiled it with pigs and with fornication. Furthermore, because of the transgression of the Jewish people, he cast truth to the ground. This means that there was no righteousness or justice.

**e. Arising, being of fierce countenance and skilled in ambiguities**

Verse 23 speaks of him as the king that would arise, being of fierce countenance and skilled in ambiguities. He would speak in such a manner that his word could be interpreted in many different ways.

**f. His power being mighty**

His power would be mighty but not by his own power. He would destroy in an extraordinary manner, destroying mighty men and the holy people (v. 24).

**g. Through his craftiness causing deceit to prosper in his hand**

Through his craftiness he would also cause deceit to prosper in his hand. He would magnify himself in his heart, and he would destroy many who were complacently secure (v. 25a).

**h. Standing up against the Prince of princes**

He would stand up against the Prince of princes (God), but he would be broken, yet not by human hands (v. 25b). In all these items also he typifies Antichrist (Rev. 13:6; 17:11; 19:20).

**i. The days for him to do evil things in the holy land being two thousand three hundred days**

The days for him, Antiochus Epiphanes, to do evil things in the holy land would be two thousand three hundred days, from about 171 B.C. until December 25, 165 B.C., which would be the day when the Jewish hero Maccabeus would cleanse the sanctuary after defeating Antiochus Epiphanes (Dan. 8:13-14, 26).

**IV. The interpretation of the vision**

In 8:15-27 we are given the interpretation of the vision concerning a ram and a male goat with its successors.

## **God's Economy in the Book of Daniel**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 9:26; 2:35, 44; 7:13-14; 3:23-25; 10:4-9; 4:17, 25-26; Rev. 19:7-9, 11-16, 19-21; 17:14

Although the book of Daniel is short, it has many points, it speaks of many events and persons, and it contains many spiritual lessons for us. But above, behind, and within all these things, there is something else, and this is God's economy. Of course, the expression God's economy is not found in Daniel; neither is it found anywhere else in the Old Testament. Nevertheless, God's economy is revealed in this book. We all need to see God's economy in the book of Daniel. If we see this vision of God's economy, our whole being will be changed.

### **Christ — the centrality and universality of God's economy**

Christ is the centrality and universality of God's economy, and God's economy is for Christ to be the centrality and universality in God's move. This is what we must see in our reading of the book of Daniel. The various spiritual lessons and the historical details covered in this book are very good, but they are secondary. What is primary is that in His economy, in His plan with His arrangement, God desires to make Christ the centrality and universality of His move on earth.

Concerning such a Christ, the book of Daniel covers five main points: the death of Christ, the upcoming appearing of Christ, Christ as the Son of Man who comes to the throne of God to receive dominion and a kingdom, Christ as the Companion of the suffering witnesses of God, and the excellency of Christ. I would like to say a word about each of these points.

### **Christ's crucifixion**

The first point is Christ's death, Christ's crucifixion. Regarding this, 9:26 says, "After the sixty-two weeks Messiah will be cut off and will have nothing." This word is simple, but it is rich in its implications.

The death of Christ was all-inclusive, comprising every item in the universe. The main item terminated by the death of Christ was the old creation. After God's work in creation, Satan came in to corrupt, poison, devastate, and ruin God's creation. As a result, the entire old creation became not only corrupt but corruption. Yet God still uses that corrupted creation in producing a new creation through Christ's death and resurrection.

Christ's greatest achievement in His first appearing was to terminate the whole creation by His death. In this termination, however, there is something rising up, that is, Christ's resurrection. In His resurrection Christ became a life-giving Spirit (1 Cor. 15:45b) to enliven, to germinate, to regenerate, some of those in the old creation to be the new creation. This new creation begins with the believers as God's sons and Christ's members as the constituents of His Body. This Body will grow and eventually consummate in the New Jerusalem (Rev. 21—22), the total aggregate and consummation of God's new creation. This is all involved in Christ's first coming with His death and resurrection.

In the entire universe, Christ's death with His resurrection is a great landmark of the ages. His death has cleared up the entire universe by terminating the old creation spiritually.

### **The second coming of Christ**

Even though the old creation has been terminated, outwardly the world is still the same. Hence, there is the need for Christ's second coming to clear up the entire universe physically and materially. In particular, there is the need for Christ's second coming to terminate human government.

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According to Daniel 2:35 and 44, Christ will come as the stone cut out without hands to crush the great human image from the toes to the head. In His coming as such a stone, He will crush Antichrist with the ten toes. However, He will not come by Himself; He will come with His bride (Rev. 19:11, 14). Before His coming He will have a wedding, uniting His overcomers to Himself as one entity (vv. 7-9). Whereas Daniel 2 speaks of Christ coming as a stone cut out without hands, Revelation 19 speaks of Christ coming as the One who has His bride as His army.

Christ is God coming down to fight against rebellious mankind, and mankind is represented by one man who is one with Satan — Antichrist. The very God is embodied in Christ; Christ is with His bride, the overcomers; and Antichrist is one with Satan and one with the ten kings and their armies. These two parties — Christ and Antichrist — will fight. Man will fight against God directly (Rev. 19:19-21; 17:14). The most evil persons on earth will be gathered by Antichrist to one place; that is, the grapes will be gathered together into the winepress (19:15; 14:19-20). Then Christ will come not only to crush the ten toes but also to tread the winepress. This will be Christ's crushing of the human government.

After crushing the human government, God will have cleared up the entire universe. The old creation will be gone, and the human government will become chaff blown away by the wind. Then the corporate Christ, Christ with His overcomers, will become a great mountain to fill the whole earth, making the whole earth God's kingdom (Dan. 2:35, 44). Both the earth and the heaven will then be new for God to exercise His kingdom.

### **Christ as the Son of Man receiving dominion and a kingdom**

Daniel 7:13-14 reveals that now Christ as the Son of Man is before the throne of God to receive dominion and a kingdom. He is making all the preparations to come back to rule over the entire world with God's kingdom.

### **Christ as the companion of God's suffering people**

While Christ is preparing to come back with the kingdom, He is also the Companion of God's suffering people (3:23-25). Because of the wrong government, God's people are in the "furnace," yet Christ is with them.

### **Christ in His excellency**

Furthermore, 10:4-9 reveals Christ in His excellency. Every part of Christ is excellent and precious. He is the excellent One in the whole universe. This excellent One is the centrality and universality of God's economy.

### **Christ becoming the centrality and universality of God's elect through their environment**

The book of Daniel also reveals that it is through their environment that Christ becomes the centrality and universality of God's elect. Through the nations as the environment, in the coming days God will eventually make Christ the centrality and universality of Israel. The principle is the same with us today. In this present age of mystery, which is not revealed in Daniel, God is using the environment to make Christ the centrality and universality to us.

We are not simple. On the one hand, we, the believers in Christ, are God's elect; on the other hand, we are parts of the old creation, including such negative things as the beasts described in Daniel 7. As God's elect, we need Christ to be wrought into us as our centrality and universality. However, the old creation in us is sometimes a beast and at other times a Nebuchadnezzar or an Antichrist seeking to defeat, capture, possess, and utilize God's elect. Since we are complicated in this way, we also need to be a Daniel and open our windows toward Jerusalem and pray that Christ will come in to cut off, to terminate, everything in us that is natural and part of the old creation.

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Christ becomes our centrality and universality by His appearing in two aspects. First, He has come to terminate us as the old creation and then to germinate us as the new creation. Second, He will come to clear away all the beasts. Depending on our culture and nationality, we all have our own beasts. Those from one part of the world have one kind of beast, and those from another part have a different kind of beast. We need Christ to receive the kingdom from God and come to crush all the beasts and then to become a great mountain that comprises us and that fills the whole earth to be the kingdom of God. By terminating and germinating us and by crushing all the beasts in us, Christ is wrought into our being to become our centrality and universality.

### **Three crucial matters in the book of Daniel — God's heavenly rule, the preeminence of Christ, and the portion of God's people**

The book of Daniel covers three crucial matters: God's heavenly rule, the preeminence of Christ, and the portion of God's people. In His economy God administrates the universe in order to fulfill His purpose. His purpose is to give Christ the preeminence in all things. God's intention, therefore, is that Christ should be preeminent. For Christ to be the preeminent One, God needs a people. Apart from God's having a people, there is no way for Christ to be made preeminent.

As those who have been chosen by God to be His people for Christ's preeminence, we are under God's heavenly rule. Concerning this, the principle is the same both in the Old Testament and in the New Testament. Under God's heavenly rule, everything is working together for our good (Rom. 8:28). This is especially true of the things in our personal universe. Our universe includes ourselves, our families, and the church. In our universe many things happen day by day for the purpose of making Christ preeminent. We need to realize this and be submissive to God's heavenly rule.

In 4:26 Daniel said to Nebuchadnezzar, "Your kingdom will be assured to you after you have come to know that the heavens do rule." It is the heavens that rule, not Nebuchadnezzar or Cyrus or Alexander the Great or illness or turmoil or rebellion. The earth is under the rule of a heavenly administration. The heavens rule for us, and Christ is for us. Furthermore, we are under God's heavenly rule for Christ. The purpose of the heavenly ruling is to complete God's elect so that Christ may be preeminent, that He may be the first — the centrality — and everything — the universality.

Because the heavens rule, Christ is with us in all our situations. When we are sick, He is with us. When we are in turmoil, He is with us. I can testify that we can enjoy His presence in the midst of turmoil and rebellion.

We all need to learn three things: that this universe is under God's administration; that God's intention in His administration is to make Christ preeminent, to cause Him to have the first place in everything; and that for the accomplishment of God's intention, we, His people, His elect, must give Him the best coordination and cooperation. Through our coordination and cooperation, God will consummate His eternal intention to make Christ preeminent through the rule of the heavens.



## **Human Government Fighting Against God and Being Crushed by Christ in His Coming with His Bride**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 2:31-35, 41-44; Rev. 19:7-9, 11-21; 17:14

We should not study the Word or understand the Word in a natural way but study and understand it according to the Lord's revelation and enlightenment. To see that Daniel prayed three times a day does not require enlightenment, but to see God's economy in the book of Daniel requires vision, revelation, and enlightenment. Because we need vision, revelation, and enlightenment, Paul prayed that the Father would give us a spirit of wisdom and revelation in the full knowledge of Him (Eph. 1:17). We also need the proper interpretation of the Word.

In this message I would like to give a further word concerning the problem presented to God by human government. My burden is to point out that eventually human government will fight against God and will be crushed by Christ in His coming with His bride.

### **Antichrist and His ten kings fighting against God directly**

In the great human image described in Daniel, the head was of gold, the breast and the arms were of silver, the abdomen and thighs were of bronze, the legs were of iron, and the feet and the toes were partly of iron and partly of clay. Apparently, the parts that were of gold, silver, bronze, and iron were not a problem to God. But with the ten toes there is a great problem, for when human government reaches the stage of the ten toes — the stage of Antichrist and his ten kings — it will fight against God directly. Thus, human government not only rebels against God, exalts man, and worships idols but also fights against God directly. However, Christ, the embodiment of God, will come with His bride to crush the human government.

### **In the new creation Christ preparing a bride for himself**

Before the human government is crushed, there will be a long history, both of the world and of the new creation. It is in the new creation that Christ prepares a bride for Himself to marry. If Christ did not have a bride, then He would have to fight alone against Antichrist, for Antichrist would have an army but Christ would not. However, Christ will have an army, and this army will be His bride.

The book of Ephesians reveals that the church is not only Christ's bride but is also a warrior (6:10-20). On the day of His wedding, Christ will marry the one who has been fighting the battle against God's enemy for years. This means that in Revelation 19 Christ will marry the overcomers, who have already overcome the evil one.

This defeated evil one, the devil, will then seek to join himself to Antichrist, and Antichrist will welcome him. The devil and Antichrist will become one. Inspired by the devil, Antichrist will gather together a multitude of evil persons to be his army. In the sight of God, these evil ones, the army of Antichrist, will be the grapes that will be trodden in "the winepress of the fury of the wrath of God the Almighty" (Rev. 19:15).

When Christ comes to fight against Antichrist and his army, He will come as the Son of Man. As the Son of Man, He will need a counterpart to match Him and complete Him. This counterpart will be His bride. In His coming to crush human government, Christ will be the Husband with the overcomers as His bride. This means that before He descends to earth to deal with the ten toes and then with the entire image, He will have a wedding (Rev. 19:7-9). After His wedding, He will come with His newly-married bride to destroy Antichrist, who with his army will fight against God directly.

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### **The way Christ deals with the old creation and the human government**

In a previous message we pointed out that both the old creation and human government are problems to God. Christ dealt with the problem of the old creation through His crucifixion, His all-inclusive death on the cross. This problem He solved alone. Christ will deal with the problem of human government by coming with His bride to crush the great image from the toes to the head. This problem He will solve not alone but with His bride as His army. Christ with His bride will annihilate the human government.

### **Christ producing His bride in the new creation by growth and transformation**

Now we need to go on to see by what way Christ produces His bride. He produces the bride by the way of the new creation. In the Lord's recovery today, we are fighting against traditional, organized religion and are fighting for the new creation. Traditional, organized religion does not help the believers to grow, to be renewed, and to be transformed. Many of us can testify that we did not begin to grow spiritually until we came into the church life.

Growth is followed by transformation. Both in our physical life and in our spiritual life, we are transformed by growing. The more we grow, the more we are transformed.

Because traditional, organized religion does not help God's people to grow, there is the need for the Lord's recovery. We need the recovery, and God also has a need for the recovery. The Lord's recovery is absolutely for the new creation. For this reason, from the time I came to this country in 1962, I have been giving messages on the matter of transformation. The Lord's recovery is for the new creation, and the new creation requires transformation from the old into the new. In addition to being transformed, we also need to be built up together so that we may be the Body of Christ and also the bride of Christ, the counterpart of Christ.

Christ needs the Body and the bride. Before His second appearing, He will continue to work in the church in a mysterious way to make us a new creation. When this new creation has been transformed and has become mature in life, it will be attached to Christ and become one with Him to be His bride.

I want to stress the fact that the bride requires maturity. Christ will not marry a bride who is immature. Only when we have reached maturity will He take us to be His bride. We must admit that in the Lord's recovery we have not yet reached maturity; we are still too young to be presented to Christ as His bride. Thus, there is the urgent need for maturity. When Christ, the Bridegroom, sees that we have reached maturity, He will marry the bride and then come with her as His army to crush the human government.

### **Christ as the centrality and universality in God's economy**

After Christ has married His bride, He will come as the stone cut out without hands and will crush the great human image from the toes to the head, destroying the human government which fights against God directly. Through this crushing the whole earth will be cleared up. The problem of the human government in the old creation will be solved. Then Christ will increase from a stone to a great mountain that fills the whole earth (Dan. 2:35). In this way Christ will be the centrality and the universality in God's economy.

The stone refers to Christ as the centrality, and the mountain refers to Him as the universality. As the stone He is the center, the centrality; as the mountain He is the circumference, the universality. Today Christ must be the centrality and universality in our church life, family life, and daily life. If Christ is our centrality and universality in this way, He will also be the centrality and universality in God's economy and in God's move.

### **All kings and kingdoms being under God's administration**

The book of Daniel shows us that all the kings and kingdoms of the world are under God's administration. Consider the situation of the Babylonian Empire under Nebuchadnezzar. First, he became a co-regent with his father and reigned with him. As such a co-regent he destroyed the city of Jerusalem in 606 B.C. Then about 604 B.C. he became king and reigned until 561 B.C. Eventually he was replaced by his son and then by his grandson, Belshazzar, whose debauchery in Daniel 5 was an insult to God and who was slain in 538 B.C. At that time the Babylonian Empire came to an end, and Darius the Mede received the kingdom at the age of sixty-two. Darius was a subordinate king to Cyrus (see Daniel 8). In 536 B.C. Cyrus issued the decree that released the captives of Israel to return to Judah, thus ending the seventy years which God had apportioned for the Israelites to remain in Babylon. Therefore, God used the Babylonian Empire for the purpose of carrying His corrupted and defeated elect into captivity. After the seventy years of their captivity, God caused the Medes and the Persians to become one for the purpose of ending the Babylonian Empire and of releasing His people from their captivity in Babylon. This is an illustration of how all kings and kingdoms are under God's administration.

In the book of Isaiah, Nebuchadnezzar and Babylon are condemned, but Cyrus is highly regarded. Isaiah 14 reveals the oneness of Satan and Babylon. In the eyes of the prophet Isaiah, Nebuchadnezzar was one with Satan. Concerning Cyrus, on the contrary, Isaiah says that God delighted in him and even made him a shepherd to care for His people. In the first year of his reign, Cyrus proclaimed the return of God's people to Judah (Ezra 1:1-4). He also arranged for the vessels of the house of God which Nebuchadnezzar had brought to Babylon to be returned to Jerusalem. Thus, Cyrus is presented in a very positive way. Nevertheless, he was still part of the great image, that is, a part of the human government which will consummate in Antichrist, who will fight against God directly. This exposes how evil the human government is.

### **Christ preparing everything for His coming back to exercise His dominion on earth**

In order to deal with this evil human government, Christ as the Son of Man must receive the kingdom (Dan. 7:13-14). On the one hand, Christ is in the heavens as the One who has received the kingdom. On the other hand, Christ is in us as the life-giving Spirit (1 Cor. 15:45b). As our Redeemer, He terminated the old creation by His crucifixion. As the One in resurrection, He has germinated the new creation, and today He is working within us as His new creation. He is also our Companion in the burning furnace (Dan. 3). As such a wonderful One, He is preparing everything for His coming back to exercise His dominion over the whole earth.

## **The Visions of the Overcoming Daniel**

(3)

### **The Vision Concerning the Seventy Weeks**

Scripture Reading: Dan. 9

Daniel 9:24-27 is the most precious portion in the entire book of Daniel. The seventy weeks mentioned in these verses are the key to understanding the prophecies of the Bible. In this message we will consider the vision of the seventy weeks.

#### **I. The year of the vision**

The year of this vision was the first year of Darius (about 538 B.C.), son of Ahasuerus (Ezra 4:6; Esth. 1:1-2), a Median descendant (Dan. 9:1-2a).

#### **II. The cause of the vision**

The cause of the vision is described in 9:2b. "I, Daniel, understood by means of the Scriptures the number of the years, which came as the word of Jehovah to Jeremiah the prophet, for the completion of the desolations of Jerusalem, that is, seventy years." The word of Jehovah to Jeremiah is found in Jeremiah 25:11-12; 29:10-14.

#### **III. The way to obtain the vision**

In Daniel 9:3-23 we see the way to obtain this vision — Daniel's desperate seeking of the Lord God in prayer and supplications with fasting.

##### **A. Confessing his sins and the sins of the people**

In his prayer Daniel confessed his own sins and the sins of the kings, the chief men, and the fathers of Israel, and of all the people of Israel (vv. 3-15, 20a).

##### **B. Supplicating for God's interests on earth**

In his prayer Daniel also supplicated for the holy city of Jerusalem, the holy mountain of God, and the holy people of God (vv. 16-17, 19b, 20b). This means that he supplicated for all the interests of God on the earth, not for his own interest.

##### **C. Asking the Lord to forgive them**

Furthermore, Daniel asked the Lord to forgive them, not based upon their righteousness but based upon God's great compassion (vv. 18-19a).

##### **D. God's answer to Daniel's prayer and supplication**

In verses 21 through 23 we have God's answer to Daniel's prayer and supplication. God's answer was Gabriel's relating of the seventy weeks commanded by God.

In his desperate prayer, Daniel requested that God recover the holy land, send His people back, and rebuild the holy city (vv. 15-19). But God answered him by giving him the report through the angel Gabriel of the seventy weeks (vv. 20-27). This answer exceeded what Daniel requested.

#### **IV. The contents of the vision**

Verses 24 through 27 are the contents of the vision. The contents are the seventy weeks.

##### **A. The destiny apportioned by God**

The seventy weeks are the destiny apportioned by God for His people and for His holy city (v. 24a).

##### **B. The purpose**

The purpose of the seventy weeks is to close the transgression, to make an end of sins, to make propitiation for iniquity, to bring in the righteousness of the ages, to seal up vision and prophet, and to anoint the holy of holies (v. 24b). Today in the old creation under human government, transgression, sins, and iniquity are prevailing. When Christ comes to crush human government, at the time appointed, the transgression will be closed, sins will be ended, and iniquity will be propitiated.

Then the righteousness of the ages will be brought in. The expression of the ages is a Hebrew idiom which means "eternity" or "eternal." Hence, the righteousness of the ages is an eternal righteousness. The coming kingdom age will be an age of divine righteousness, and in the new heaven and new earth, there will be eternal righteousness (2 Pet. 3:13).

Daniel 9:24b also speaks of the sealing up of vision and prophet. The vision and prophet will be sealed because everything will be fulfilled. There will, therefore, be no need of visions or prophets. In the kingdom age, there will be kings and priests but no prophets.

The last aspect of the purpose of the seventy weeks is to anoint the holy of holies. At the time of Daniel's prayer, the holy of holies was contaminated, defiled, and devastated. But when the apportioned time comes, the holy of holies will be properly anointed. This means that the service to God will be recovered. What a blessing!

##### **C. The seventy weeks**

Daniel 9:24-27 tells us of the seventy weeks. The seventy weeks are divided into three parts, with each week being seven years, not seven days, in length.

### **1. The seven weeks of forty-nine years**

First, seven weeks of forty-nine years were apportioned from the issuing of the decree to restore and rebuild Jerusalem to the completion of the rebuilding (v. 25).

### **2. The sixty-two weeks of four hundred thirty-four years**

Second, sixty-two weeks of four hundred thirty-four years were apportioned from the completion of the rebuilding of Jerusalem to the cutting off of the Messiah (vv. 25-26). "Messiah will be cut off and will have nothing" (v. 26). This refers to the crucifixion of Christ. The cutting off of Messiah — the crucifixion of Christ — was the termination of the old creation with the human government in the old creation and the germination through the resurrection of Christ of God's new creation with God's eternal kingdom as the divine administration in God's new creation. Thus, the cross of Christ is the centrality and universality of God's work.

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This word concerning Messiah's being cut off is not bad news but good news. Through His death on the cross, Christ terminated the old creation. Then in His resurrection He became the life-giving Spirit (1 Cor. 15:45b) to germinate those whom God has chosen and make them a new creation. If we see this, we will realize that the word in Daniel 9:26 about the death of Christ is good news.

Whereas the first part of verse 26 speaks of the death of Christ, the remainder of this verse speaks of another matter. "The people of the prince who will come will destroy the city and the sanctuary" (v. 26b). This reveals that the prince of the Roman Empire, Titus, would come with his army to destroy the city and the sanctuary — the temple. The Lord Jesus also prophesied concerning this destruction in Matthew 24:2. This destruction took place in A.D. 70. As Daniel 9:26c goes on to say, the end of it would be with a flood, and even to the end there would be war. The desolations have been determined.

### **3. The one week of seven years**

Finally, in verse 27 we have the one week of seven years. This week will be for Antichrist to make a firm covenant with the people of Israel.

Between the sixty-ninth week and the last week, there is a gap which has already lasted for nearly two thousand years. In this gap the church is being secretly and mysteriously built by Christ in His resurrection to be the Body of Christ and bride of Christ. Also, in this gap Israel has been suffering, having lost their fathers' homeland and having been scattered. Nevertheless, God has not forgotten His people Israel but continues to grant them some degree of mercy. Eventually, the last week of seven years will come.

#### **a. Antichrist causing the sacrifice and oblation to cease**

Antichrist will make a firm covenant with the people of Israel, promising to be for them. The covenant he makes with them will be a peace agreement. However, in the middle of the seventieth week, Antichrist will change his mind, fight against God, and cause the sacrifice and oblation to cease (v. 27b). This will be the beginning of the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21), which will last for three and a half years. During the great tribulation, both the faithful Jews and the Christians still on earth will suffer Antichrist's persecution.

#### **b. Antichrist replacing the sacrifice and the oblation with the abominations of the desolator**

After he causes the sacrifice and the oblation to cease, Antichrist will replace them with the abominations (the idols of the Antichrist — 2 Thes. 2:4) of the desolator (Dan. 9:27c). This desolator is Antichrist himself.

#### **c. Complete destruction being poured out upon the desolator**

Eventually, the complete destruction that has been determined will be poured out upon the desolator, Antichrist (v. 27d).

What Daniel received regarding the seventy weeks was not only a vision but also a report. Daniel understood the seventy weeks, but because we are near the end of the gap, I believe that we understand this matter even better than Daniel did. By studying the vision of seventy weeks in relation to God's economy, we will be helped to know where we are, what we should be, and what we should be doing today.

## **The Visions of the Overcoming Daniel**

(4)

### **The Vision Concerning the Destiny of Israel**

(1)

Scripture Reading: Dan. 10:1-21; 11:1

After the visions seen by Daniel in chapters seven through nine, Daniel saw the vision concerning the destiny of Israel. However, before we are told of the vision Daniel saw concerning Israel's destiny in chapter eleven, chapter ten shows us the spiritual world behind the physical. For us to know God's economy and to know that in God's economy Christ is the centrality and universality of God's move, we need to see the spiritual things behind the physical.

What we see outwardly is the physical world, but behind the physical world is the spiritual. In the spiritual world Christ is the preeminent One. Therefore, in chapter ten He is mentioned first (vv. 4-9). He is described as wearing a linen robe, being girded with a golden girdle, and having a body like beryl (vv. 5-6).

After this vision of Christ, an angelic messenger came to tell Daniel about the things behind the physical world. He told Daniel that he himself was fighting against the prince of the kingdom of Persia, a rebellious evil spirit. Then Daniel was told that there was another evil spirit, the prince of Greece (Javan). There was also the archangel Michael, who was a prince fighting for Israel. At least four spirits are covered here.

In chapter five we saw how Belshazzar was indulging in debauchery and how in the same night Darius the Mede came to defeat him and kill him. We did not see that there was a spirit fighting for Darius. Daniel 11:1 says, "I, in the first year of Darius the Mede, stood up to support and strengthen him." Darius was strong even as an old man because this heavenly messenger stood up to support him and strengthen him. The angelic messenger strengthened Darius to defeat the Babylonians because the Babylonian Empire's commission from God had been completed. With the death of Belshazzar, the Babylonian Empire became the empire of Medo-Persia to carry out another commission for God.

Darius the Mede was the first one to conquer the Babylonian Empire. However, according to Daniel 8 a ram, signifying Persia, was seen with two horns. The second horn was higher than the first, referring to Cyrus the Persian who assumed power two years later in 536 B.C. In the first year of his reign, Cyrus issued a decree to release all the captives of Israel back to the land of their forefathers and to rebuild the temple. Because Cyrus supported them, supplied them, and protected them, Isaiah said that Cyrus was a shepherd of God to take care of God's people (Isa. 44:28).

Apparently, all of these struggles are merely the activities of human governments represented by the great human image in Daniel 2. Actually, God was behind the physical world managing the entire situation. This is what we need to see as we consider chapter ten of Daniel and the vision of Israel's destiny in chapter eleven.

#### **I. The year of this vision**

"In the third year of Cyrus king of Persia a word was revealed to Daniel, who was named Belteshazzar" (10:1a). The third year of Cyrus, the king of Persia, the year of this vision, was about 534 B.C., when Daniel was eighty-seven years of age.

#### **II. The main subject of the vision**

The main subject of the vision concerning the destiny of Israel is the great distress. The Hebrew word translated distress in 10:1b denotes trial, distress, conflict, warfare, or an army. Here it refers to a great distress suffered by God's people. That distress came upon Israel from a war between the king of the south and the king of the north, referring to Egypt and Syria respectively. When Syria and Egypt fought each other, they waged war on Israel's land because it was used as a thoroughfare for the two kings to invade each other. These wars were a distress, a trial, to the children of Israel. This was especially true of the war that was waged by a descendant of one of the four successors of Alexander the Great who was at that time the king of Syria. This descendant, Antiochus Epiphanes, a full type of Antichrist, was a real trial sent by God to His chosen people, because they had become corrupt after their return from captivity.

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#### **III. The scene in the universe before the release of this vision**

Daniel 10:2—11:1 shows us the scene in the universe — the spiritual world behind the physical — before the release of this vision.

##### **A. Daniel setting his heart to understand the future of Israel**

Daniel, a man on the earth, set his heart to understand the future, the destiny, of Israel (vv. 2-3, 12). This he did for twenty-one days.

##### **B. The excellent Christ appearing to Daniel**

After those twenty-one days, Daniel saw a particular vision in 10:4-9. The excellent Christ, the centrality and universality of God's move on the earth, appeared to Daniel for his appreciation, consolation, encouragement, expectation, and stabilization.

Before showing Daniel the great distress, God revealed to him the excellent man described in these verses. Daniel may not have known that this man was the Messiah, but I believe that Daniel understood that this One was the Lord as a man. That man was not only Jehovah but Jehovah becoming a man.

In our eyes the incarnation took place at a definite point in time, whereas in God's view there is only the fact but no time element. In the universe there is the fact that the Triune God became a man. This is revealed in Matthew and Luke. But in Genesis 18 when three persons came to Abraham, there was one among the three who was Jesus. He came as a man to visit Abraham. In Daniel 10 this man appeared to Daniel. When He appeared as a man to Abraham, He was an ordinary man with no particular characteristics. However, He appeared to Daniel with many wonderful characteristics. This excellent Christ appeared to Daniel for his appreciation, consolation, encouragement, expectation, and stabilization.

##### **1. In His priesthood**

First, the excellent Christ appeared in His priesthood for taking care of His chosen people (v. 5a). His priesthood is signified by the linen robe. He appeared to Daniel not wearing armor for fighting but dressed in a linen robe, the Old Testament priestly garment. In typology, linen signifies humanity. The fact that Christ is clothed in linen signifies that His humanity is His priestly robe. At the time of Daniel 10, Christ Himself, God's centrality and universality, was a Priest taking care of the children of Israel in captivity. He is a Priest in His humanity taking care of God's captive people.

## **2. In His kingship**

Second, Christ appeared to Daniel in His kingship (signified by the golden girdle) for ruling over all the peoples. Verse 5b says that His "loins were girded with the fine gold of Uphaz." A girdle is for strengthening. Christ's kingship is signified not by linen but by gold. His priesthood is human, whereas His kingship is divine.

## **3. In His preciousness and dignity**

Furthermore, for His people's appreciation Christ appeared also in His preciousness and dignity as signified by His body being like beryl (v. 6a). The Hebrew word for beryl here is not easily translated. Darby uses the term chrysolite. The Hebrew word could refer to a bluish-green or yellow precious stone. This signifies that Christ in His embodiment is divine (yellow), full of life (green), and heavenly (blue).

## **4. In His brightness**

Furthermore, Christ appeared in His brightness for shining over the people. His brightness is signified by His face being like the appearance of lightning (v. 6b).

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## **5. In His enlightening sight**

Christ's enlightening sight for searching and judging is signified by His eyes being like torches of fire (v. 6c).

## **6. In His gleam in His work and moves**

Christ also appeared in His gleam in His work and moves, tested by people and testing people. His gleam in His work and moves is signified by His arms and His feet being like the gleam of polished bronze (v. 6d). In typology, bronze signifies God's judgment, which makes people bright. God's judgment is a kind of trial. Christ was judged, tried, by God, and God's trial and judgment made Him bright like polished bronze. Such a Christ is the One who has been tested by others and who also tests others.

## **7. In His strong speaking**

Finally, Christ appeared to Daniel in His strong speaking for judging people. His strong speaking is signified by the sound of His words being like the sound of a multitude (v. 6e).

The Christ whom Daniel saw was such a One. He is precious, valuable, complete, and perfect. As a man He is the very centrality and universality of God's move to carry out His economy. He is so precious, bright, shining, enlightening, and testing. As the Priest He is taking care of us, and as the King He is ruling over us. How wonderful He is!

It was not with his physical eyes that Daniel saw this vision of Christ. Verse 7 says, "I, Daniel, alone saw the vision, for the men who were with me did not see the vision." Because the vision of Christ was spiritual, not physical, it was seen only by Daniel and not by those who relied on their physical sight. Concerning seeing the vision of Christ, the physical view avails nothing. For this reason, in the eyes of the worldly people, Jesus is merely a human being. But under God's mercy and with a spiritual view, we may see how dear and precious Christ is. We all need to see the Christ Daniel saw. May we all see the vision of the excellent Christ in chapter ten of Daniel.

## **C. The evil prince of the kingdom of Persia withstanding the sent angelic messenger**

Following the vision concerning Christ as the precious One in God's move, we see something regarding the spiritual struggle in the air. According to verses 10 through 17, the evil prince of the kingdom of Persia withstood the sent angelic messenger, probably one of the chief princes, for twenty-one days. Michael, one of the chief princes, came to help the sent angelic messenger, and the sent messenger remained there with the kings of Persia. The evil prince of the kingdom of Persia must have been an evil spirit, a rebellious angel, who followed Satan in his rebellion against God and who was commissioned by Satan to help Persia. This evil spirit struggled against the sent angelic messenger for twenty-one days. This means that while Daniel was praying for all those days, a spiritual struggle was taking place in the air between two spirits, one belonging to Satan and the other belonging to God. They were fighting because the sent angelic messenger (he might have been Gabriel) had been sent by God in answer to Daniel's prayer. Michael came to help the sent angelic messenger. Just as the archangel Michael fought in Jude 9, so he came in to fight here in Daniel. The crucial point we need to see is that behind the scene a spiritual struggle, a struggle not seen with physical eyes, was taking place.

## **D. The angelic messenger returning to fight with the evil prince of Persia**

In verses 18 through 21 we see more of the spiritual struggle behind the scene. The angelic messenger would return to fight with the evil prince of Persia. The evil prince of Greece was then about to come. No one would hold with the angelic messenger against these two evil princes except Michael, the prince of Israel. The name Michael means "Who is like God?"

## **E. The angelic messenger standing up to support and strengthen Darius**

In the first year of Darius the Mede, the angelic messenger stood up to support and strengthen Darius (11:1). Darius was strengthened in this way in order to receive the kingdom.

Before the vision concerning the destiny of Israel was unveiled to Daniel, he was given a vision of the spiritual scene that is behind the physical scene. In this spiritual scene Christ is preeminent. This scene also includes both good and evil spirits, spirits that are engaged in an invisible spiritual war.

## **The Visions of the Overcoming Daniel**

(4)

### **The Vision Concerning the Destiny of Israel**

(2)

Scripture Reading: Dan. 11:2-45

In this message we will begin to consider the contents of the vision concerning the destiny of Israel.

#### **IV. The contents of this vision**

The contents of this vision concern the destiny of Israel from the last part of the kingdom of Persia to the last three and a half years of the present age, even including the kingdom age and eternity, as the truth that was inscribed in the writing of truth (10:21) told to Daniel by the angelic messenger (11:2—12:13).

The vision in chapter eleven covers the details of the Persian Empire, the Grecian Empire, and the Roman Empire to its very end under Antichrist. As we will see, shortly after defeating the kingdom of Persia, Alexander the Great died, and his kingdom was divided into four kingdoms under his four generals. Two of these kingdoms, Egypt and Syria, fought wars back and forth through the land of Israel. Eventually, this chapter stresses the kingdoms and evils of two kings: Antiochus Epiphanes, one of the kings of the north (vv. 21-35), and Antichrist, the king of the restored Roman Empire (vv. 36-45).

I would emphasize once again that the great human image in Daniel 2 is the controlling factor of the entire prophecy of this book. This means that the principle of Daniel's prophecy is to cover the entire human image from the head (Babylon) to the toes (Antichrist with the ten kings). We may say that the first five chapters of Daniel give us a full definition and description of the Babylonian Empire. Chapter six begins to speak concerning the Persian Empire. In chapter seven we have a sketch of the four beasts, which from another angle portray the empires signified by the various parts of the great image. The ram in chapter eight refers to the Persian Empire, and the goat, to the Grecian Empire. In chapter nine Daniel received the vision of the seventy weeks, and in chapter ten, the vision concerning the excellent Christ, the One who is the centrality and universality of God's move. Chapter eleven provides further details regarding the Persian Empire, the Grecian Empire, and the restored Roman Empire under Antichrist during the last three and a half years of this age. From this we see that the book of Daniel covers the entire human government from the Babylonian Empire to the Roman Empire. In keeping with this principle, chapter eleven does not stop with the Grecian Empire but includes a word about Antichrist, the king of the restored Roman Empire.

Daniel 11 speaks first of the type, Antiochus Epiphanes, and then of the fulfillment of that type, Antichrist. This is according to the principle found in 9:26-27. Verse 26a speaks of Christ's crucifixion. Then the rest of the verse refers to the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple by Titus and his army in A.D. 70. However, the next verse refers not to Titus but to Antichrist, the one who makes "a firm covenant with the many for one week." In 9:26-27 first the type is revealed, then the fulfillment. The principle is the same concerning Antiochus Epiphanes and Antichrist in chapter eleven.

#### **A. Related to the king of the south and the king of the north**

The vision in Daniel 11 is related to the king of the south (Egypt) and the king of the north (Syria). Chapter eleven is a record of the fighting of these kings with each other.

##### **1. The fighting of the last king of the kingdom of Persia against the kingdom of Greece**

Verses 2b and 3 speak of the fighting of the last king of the kingdom of Persia against the kingdom of Greece and the defeat of Persia by the mighty king of Greece, Alexander the Great, about 356-323 B.C. (8:5-8a, 20-21; 7:5-6a). The death of Belshazzar in 538 B.C. marked the end of the Babylonian Empire and the beginning of the Medo-Persian Empire, which lasted until 336 B.C. The last king of this empire was defeated by Alexander the Great.

##### **2. The kingdom of Greece under Alexander the Great being divided into four kingdoms under his four generals**

Daniel 11:4, referring to Alexander the Great, says, "But once he arises, his kingdom will be broken and divided toward the four winds of heaven, but not to his posterity, nor according to his dominion with which he ruled; for his kingdom will be plucked up and given to others besides his descendants." This indicates that, after the death of Alexander the Great, his kingdom was divided into four parts (8:8b, 22; 7:6b) under the rule of his four generals: the kingdoms of Ptolemy (Egypt), of Cassander (Macedonia), of Lysimachus (Asia Minor), and of Seleucus (Syria).

##### **3. The wars back and forth between the king of the south and the king of the north**

Daniel 11:5-20 speaks of the wars back and forth between the king of the south — Egypt — and the king of the north — Syria. As these kings fought each other, they passed through Israel. Thus, Israel was in distress. The great distress mentioned in 10:1 refers mainly to the wars in chapter eleven.

##### **a. The kings using their daughters to destroy the other side**

As 11:6 and 17b indicate, both the king of the south and the king of the north followed the strategy of using their daughters to destroy the other side. However, in this matter they both were failures.

##### **b. The king of the north standing in the beautiful land of Israel**

The king of the north once stood in the beautiful land of Israel and made destruction (v. 16b).

##### **4. The kingdom and the evils of Antiochus Epiphanes as one of the kings of the north**

Daniel 11:21-45 and 8:23-25 describe the kingdom and the evils of Antiochus Epiphanes as one of the kings of the north. Chapter eleven places a great deal of emphasis on Antiochus Epiphanes because he, a full type of Antichrist, did so much damage to the temple, defiling and destroying it.

**a. A despicable person who seized the kingdom by smooth and cunning words and actions**

Antiochus was a despicable person. He came in a time of security and seized the kingdom by smooth and cunning words and actions (11:21).

**b. Defeating the king of the south**

According to verse 25, Antiochus Epiphanes defeated the king of the south.

**c. Being enraged at the holy covenant**

Verse 30 reveals that Antiochus Epiphanes was enraged at the holy covenant and took action.

**d. His armies profaning the sanctuary**

The armies of Antiochus Epiphanes profaned the sanctuary, removed the daily sacrifice, and set up the abomination that desolates (v. 31). Sacrifices, circumcision, and keeping the Sabbath were absolutely forbidden. Antiochus Epiphanes even went so far as to erect an altar to Zeus on the altar of burnt offering in the temple. This was the "abomination that desolates" mentioned in verse 31. Moreover, he set up his own image in the temple, sacrificed a sow on the altar, and sprinkled its blood in the temple. He forced the holy people to worship the idol and eat pork, and he seduced young men to commit fornication in the temple.

**e. Persecuting and slaying the devoted Jews**

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In verses 33 through 35 we see that Antiochus Epiphanes persecuted and slew the devoted Jews.

Verse 32b says, "The people who know their God will show strength and take action." This refers to Judas Maccabeus and his people, who were encouraged and strengthened by this word in the book of Daniel to take action against Antiochus Epiphanes and his armies. Verses 33 through 35 go on to speak more concerning the Maccabees. Verses 33 tells us that "those with insight among the people will cause the many to understand," that is, to teach others to understand God's will. According to verse 34, the Maccabees would receive a little help, and many joined themselves to them in word only. Finally, verse 35 says, "Some of those with insight will fall, in order to refine the people and to purify and cleanse them, until the time of the end, for the end is still at the appointed time."

**f. Being a type of Antichrist**

In all the abovementioned evils, Antiochus Epiphanes was a type of Antichrist, who will come in the last week of the seventy weeks (9:27; Matt. 24:15; 2 Thes. 2:3b-4; Rev. 13:4-7).

Whereas verses 21 through 35 of Daniel 11 refer to Antiochus Epiphanes, verses 36 through 45 refer to Antichrist. Antichrist will have no regard for anyone or anything; he will do as he pleases. He will exalt himself and magnify himself above every god, and against the God of gods he will speak extraordinary things (v. 36). He will not regard the gods of his fathers or the desire of women, nor will he regard any other god, for he will magnify himself above all (v. 37). He will honor instead a god of fortresses, and he will take action against the most fortified of fortresses with the help of a foreign god (vv. 38-39). At the time of the end, the king of the south will push against him, and the king of the north will storm back at him. He will enter the countries and overflow and pass through (v. 40). After entering the beautiful land, he will stretch out his hand against the countries (vv. 41-42). But news from the east and from the north will trouble him, and he will go forth with great wrath destroying and exterminating many (v. 44). He will pitch the tents of his palace between the Mediterranean Sea and the beautiful mountain of Zion; but he will come to his end, and there will be none to help him (v. 45).

Antichrist will come to his end when Christ as the stone cut out without hands comes with His bride to smash the great human image from the toes to the head. During the church age, the age of mystery, Christ is building up the church to be His bride. In Revelation 19 Christ will marry His bride and then come with her as His army to deal with Antichrist and his armies, which will be gathered around the city of Jerusalem. Since Antichrist will not believe in God or Christ but only in himself, the appearing of Christ with His bride will be a great surprise to Antichrist and his followers. For his enjoyment Antichrist will pitch the tents of his palace between the Mediterranean Sea and the beautiful holy mountain. At that juncture Christ will come with His bride to bring Antichrist to his end.

According to the Bible, Antichrist will destroy the temple in Jerusalem. The first temple was built by Solomon, and that temple was destroyed by Nebuchadnezzar. Then after seventy years, Cyrus the king of Persia released the captives of Israel to return to their fathers' land to rebuild the temple. Eventually, Antiochus Epiphanes, a descendant of the king of the north, utterly desecrated the temple, profaning it with idolatry, fornication, and unclean offerings. The Maccabees defeated this king and cleansed the temple. That cleansing was a justification, declaring that the temple was the holy place for God's people to worship Him. After Christ's death, Titus came with the Roman army and destroyed the temple again in A.D. 70. According to the Bible, there will be a fourth destruction of the temple by Antichrist in the middle of the last seven years of this age.

All these cases show us that the center, the aim, and the goal of Satan's struggle against God is related to the temple. God desires to have a place on earth for His people to worship Him, as a testimony that He still has an interest on this earth. But Satan is always struggling to destroy this place. If we see this, it will help us to understand the Bible.



## **The Visions of the Overcoming Daniel**

(4)

## **The Vision Concerning the Destiny of Israel**

(3)

Scripture Reading: Dan. 12

The book of Daniel covers a wide span of the Bible, from Genesis 10 to the end of the New Testament, from Babel to the New Jerusalem. As we will see, the vision in Daniel 12 covers things in the last three and a half years of the present age, things in the kingdom age, and things in eternity.

We have emphasized the fact that the great human image in Daniel 2 is the basic principle and controlling factor of Daniel's prophecy. This human image destroys and devastates the temple four times. The first time was by the head, Nebuchadnezzar (1:1-2); the second was by Antiochus Epiphanes, a descendant of one of the four generals of Alexander the Great's Grecian Empire (8:9-14); the third was by Titus, a prince of the Roman Empire (70 A.D.); the fourth will be by Antichrist (12:7, 11), part of the ten toes of the restored Roman Empire. Eventually this great human image consummates in fighting directly with God. Antichrist, the ten kings, and their troops will fight against Christ directly (Rev. 19:19). However, Christ with His bride will gain the victory by defeating Antichrist and His armies (Rev. 19:20-21).

The contents of the vision in Daniel 11:2—12:13 concern the destiny of Israel from the last part of the kingdom of Persia to the last three and a half years of the present age, even including the kingdom age and eternity. As we come to Daniel 12, we need to realize that in this book there is a gap in the chronicle of history from the ending of the ruling of the four successors of Alexander the Great (from about the second half of the last century B.C., the time the Roman Empire rose up to take the place of the kingdom of Greece as the world power that will end the present age) to the last three and a half years (v. 7) of the present age. In this gap is the church age of mystery.

### **B. Related to the archangel Michael's standing for Israel**

The vision concerning the destiny of Israel in chapter twelve is related to the archangel Michael's standing for Israel.

#### **1. Things in the consummation of the age**

First, Daniel 12 speaks of things in the consummation of the age (Matt. 28:20b) — the last three and a half years of the present age (Dan. 12:7; 7:25b).

##### **a. Michael standing for Israel**

At that time Michael, the great prince who stands for the children of Israel, will arise (12:1a).

##### **b. A time of distress**

There will be a time of distress (great tribulation) such as never occurred since there came to be a nation until that time (12:1b; Matt. 24:21; Jer. 30:7a).

##### **c. The shattering of the power of the holy people being completed**

During this time of distress and tribulation, the shattering of the power of the holy people will be completed (Dan. 12:7b; 7:25b; Rev. 13:5, 7a; 11:2).

##### **d. Everyone found written in the book being delivered**

Daniel 12:1c tells us that the people of Israel, everyone found written in the book, will be delivered. Those found written in the book are those whose names are written in God's book of life. The few children of Israel who will be delivered out of the hand of Antichrist will see Christ descending in the air and will repent, receive Him, and be saved.

##### **e. Many of those sleeping in the ground awaking to life eternal**

Many of those who are sleeping in the ground will awake to life eternal (vv. 2a, 13a; John 5:28-29a; 1 Thes. 4:16). The sleeping saints will rise up to be resurrected to the air to meet with Christ.

#### **2. Things in the kingdom age**

The vision in Daniel 12 also covers things in the kingdom age.

##### **a. The cleansing and recovering of the defiled and trampled temple for thirty days**

After the resurrection, the kingdom of God and of Christ will become the eternal kingdom, as signified by the great mountain (Dan. 2:35), thus ushering in the kingdom age. With the coming of the kingdom, there will be the cleansing and recovering of the defiled and trampled temple for thirty days (12:11). This will continue the last one thousand two hundred sixty days (Rev. 12:6) as the end of the previous age to make it one thousand two hundred ninety days. Just as the Maccabees cleansed the temple after it had been defiled by Antiochus Epiphanes, so the saved Jews will cleanse the temple at the beginning of the millennial kingdom.

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##### **b. The preparing and reestablishing of the priesthood for the offering of the daily sacrifice to God for forty-five days**

Daniel 12:12 says, "Blessed is he who waits and reaches the thousand three hundred and thirty-five days." With the beginning of the kingdom age, there will also be the preparing and reestablishing of the priesthood for the offering of the daily sacrifice to God for forty-five days, which will continue the one thousand two hundred ninety days to be the one thousand three hundred thirty-five days. Such an offering of the daily sacrifice to God will be a blessing to the chosen people of God (v. 12a; Joel 2:14). Forty-five days will be needed to recover the destroyed system of the worship of God with the sacrifices. The restoration of the sacrifices will be a great blessing to the people of Israel.

##### **c. The lot of the overcoming saints in the kingdom**

Daniel 12 shows us certain matters concerning the lot of the overcoming saints in the kingdom.

##### **1) The resurrected saints enjoying the eternal life**

Verse 2a indicates that the resurrected saints will enjoy the eternal life in the kingdom.

##### **2) Those who have insight shining like the shining of the heavenly expanse**

Those who have insight will shine like the shining of the heavenly expanse, and those who turn many to righteousness, like the stars in the kingdom age (vv. 3, 13b). In Matthew 13:43 the Lord Jesus spoke a similar word regarding the shining of the overcomers in the kingdom: "Then the righteous will shine forth like the sun in the kingdom of their Father."

### **3) Many who will be purified, cleansed, and refined participating in the kingdom**

Verse 10a says, "Many will be purified, cleansed, and refined." These purified, cleansed, and refined ones will participate in the kingdom.

### **4) The resurrected Daniel enjoying His lot in the kingdom**

Verse 13 says, "But you, go your way until the end, and you will rest and rise again in your lot at the end of the days." This indicates that the resurrected Daniel will enjoy his lot in the kingdom.

### **3. Things in eternity**

Finally, the vision in chapter twelve concerning the destiny of Israel includes things in eternity.

#### **a. Those who enjoy the eternal life in the kingdom continuing the enjoyment of the eternal life in eternity**

Those who will be resurrected and enjoy the eternal life in the kingdom will continue the enjoyment of the eternal life in eternity forever and ever (v. 3)

#### **b. Daniel continuing to enjoy His lot of the eternal life in eternity**

Daniel also will continue to enjoy his lot of the eternal life in eternity (v. 13b).

#### **c. Those who have perished being resurrected after the kingdom age and suffering eternal reproach and contempt in eternity**

Those who have perished will be resurrected after the kingdom age and suffer eternal reproach and contempt in eternity forever and ever (v. 2; John 5:29b; Rev. 20:15).

God has a plan, an economy. In this economy God decided in eternity to have a people created by Him and regenerated by Him to be His sons, then to be sanctified, renewed, transformed, and conformed to the image of His firstborn Son. This group of people will be the Body of Christ. When the millennial kingdom comes, the overcomers in this Body will be married to Christ; that is, they will go to Christ to be attached to Him and thus to be one with Him. They will be the co-kings with Christ in the heavenly section of the thousand-year kingdom. They will also be priests with Christ to serve God.

When Christ comes back to set up the kingdom, the small number of remaining Jews, the remnant of Israel, will also be saved and regenerated. However, because they will be the later believers, they will not participate in the heavenly section of the kingdom as kings and priests, but will rather be kept on the earth to be the priests of God in the earthly section of the thousand-year kingdom.

At the very end of this age, many of the evil ones from the nations will be gathered together by Antichrist. But Christ will come as the stone cut out without hands to smash all these evil ones. By this time the remaining Jews and the nations will be left on the earth. According to Matthew 25:31-46, Christ will gather the nations together to Him and will judge them, dividing them into two groups, the sheep (the good ones) and the goats (the evil ones). The goats will join Antichrist in the lake of fire (v. 41). The sheep will be restored (not regenerated) to the original God-created condition and will be counted by Christ as His people, His citizens of the millennial kingdom. Therefore, in the kingdom there will be three groups of people: 1) the overcoming believers in the heavenly section as kings and priests in the heavenlies; 2) the saved Jews who will be on the earth as the teaching priests to help the restored nations; and 3) the restored nations as the citizens under the ruling of the overcoming believers as the co-kings of Christ and also under the teaching and care of the saved Jews.

Although the kingdom of one thousand years will be wonderful, it will still be part of the old creation. The millennial kingdom will be the last age of the old creation. The old creation includes four ages: the age of the patriarchs, the age of the law, the age of grace, and the age of the kingdom. At the end of the thousand years of the age of the kingdom, there will be one more rebellion, requiring a further purification. Subsequently, the old heaven and the old earth will be burned in order to be renewed (2 Pet. 3:12-13). Then there will be a new heaven and new earth (Rev. 21:1). At that time the saved and regenerated Jews will join the believing saints. Also, those saints who were not overcomers before the thousand-year kingdom will have been disciplined and matured and will join the overcomers in the New Jerusalem.

The New Jerusalem includes the twelve names of the apostles and the twelve names of the twelve tribes of Israel (Rev. 21:12, 14). This indicates that all the believers who have been in fellowship with the twelve apostles and the Jews who belong to the twelve tribes will be the composition of the new city. This city will be God's tabernacle, God's dwelling place, the bride of Christ, and the mutual abode of all the saints, the believers and the Jews, for eternity. The nations who remain after the final sifting and purification (Rev. 20:7-9) will be transferred to the land in the new earth to be the citizens forever (Rev. 21:24-26). That will be the eternal kingdom of God, composed of created, regenerated, sanctified, transformed, and glorified people to be one with God for eternity, ruling over and teaching the restored nations, who will be the citizens in the new heaven and the new earth.

### **A concluding word**

Now that we have come to the end of the Life-study of Daniel, I would like to give a concluding word.

The book of Daniel shows us a man whose heart is one with God and is set absolutely on the destiny of his people, Israel. Apparently, the destiny of Israel is in the hands of the human government, the power of the nations. Actually, the destiny of Israel is in the economy of the God who has chosen them and who rules over all the human government with the heavenly authority. The human government began with Babylon, represented by Nebuchadnezzar, and will end also with Babylon, represented by Antichrist, who was typified by Antiochus Epiphanes of Syria and Titus of the Roman Empire.

Christ is the centrality and universality of God's move in the divine economy. Christ was crucified to terminate the old creation and germinate through His resurrection the new creation. He is the excellent and precious One in the appreciation and expectation of God's chosen people. He will receive the eternal kingdom from God and appear to end and smash all the human government from its toes to its head and become the enlarged kingdom of God throughout the whole earth.

In His divine economy God will perfect Israel to be His priests, and He will prepare His created and restored (not regenerated) nations to be His people. In addition to this result of the manifested part of His economy, in the hidden part of His divine economy God will complete the building up of the church as the Body of Christ to be God's royal family to rule as kings in the new heaven and new earth. Eventually, in eternity in His eternal kingdom God will have His kings, His priests, and His people forever.